if i could freeze a moment for a moment

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/65347459.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Wednesday Addams/Enid Sinclair

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by nishmonkey

Summary

It's not Enid's fault that three days go by before she realizes anything is wrong. Maybe it's naive that she hoped nothing would happen this semester, and while she's grateful there's no murdering...she almost misses it. The murders were somehow easier to deal with than the reality she's found herself in. And now she can't even look Wednesday in the eye.

OR

The one where Enid is stuck in a time loop.

Woe Is A Storm In Which Enid Is Lost

Chapter Summary

A kind of prologue showing how the first few loops find Enid and the ways in which she navigates her new normal.

Chapter Notes

Rewatched W ednesday recently and had the inspiration to rework an old WIP in my drafts. This has no correlation to anything known about season 2, so enjoy it as is.

All mistakes are my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Wednesday's child is full of woe.

That was one of the first personal anecdotes Wednesday willingly gave Enid about herself after settling in their dorm that initial night.

And because Enid wanted to know positively *everything* about her gloom-ridden new roommate—*for her blog, of courses*—she looked up the old nursery rhyme the moment she had the chance. It was basic enough. The kind of thing her parents or grandparents might have learned at some point in their youth. Interestingly , she discovered there was considerable variation and debate about the exact attributes each day was given. Unlike modern versions in which the famous statement was true, an early incarnation of the rhyme showed that which: *Friday's child is full of woe*.

The old anecdote came to mind now because while the statement still technically applied to her roommate, Enid was *also* born on a Friday and could argue that *woe* was all she knew at the moment. And she knew it in spades. Enid was so deep in the dredges of it that Wednesday would be *jealous* of all the woe she was experiencing.

Day, after day, after day, after day…

That is, if she ever told her roommate about it.

Technically, there was no reason for Enid to hold back. In fact, she could tell Wednesday absolutely anything she wanted and have zero fear of any judgments or repercussions that might come about from it. Enid could spill every secret that slept deep in her heart—every fear that fueled the infrequent night terrors she awoke from, or even whatever mundane thoughts rolled around in her head—and not have to worry about the anxiety of self-consciousness that came with confessing any of it.

The problem was… Wednesday wouldn't remember. *Enid* would.

Enid remembered everything now because *Enid*, and *Enid* alone, was stuck in an honest-to-goodness time loop.

A time loop. Time. Loop. Time. Loop. The phrase was strange on her tongue.

It was something used in sci-fi movies with fantastical plots that she occasionally watched on days after her mother had taken her to yet another doctor who did nothing but strip all confidence from her werewolf nature and have her wish for her own reset for change. It was a phenomenon that, even in a supernatural world where close friends were vampires and roommates admitted to mentally *vision-ing* themselves into the past, was just too freaky a concept to really think was possible.

So it was no wonder, now being stuck in an endlessly repeating day, that Enid blamed Wednesday for it all.

Not for causing the incident, though the jury was still out on that, but for the fact that after Wednesday showed up to Nevermore, Enid had been personally roped into more deviously supernatural spooky happenings than anyone should have bargained they'd get into after innocently enrolling at a school for Outcasts. She signed up for the

occasional stoner incident or a wolf out gone wrong—*not* the horrific murder spree that happened last semester, and definitely not whatever the hell was happening to her presently.

Enid had only longed to have a semi-normal school life: know the unknowns of gossip around campus and the nearby town, date her current crush, get good grades, and be the kind of werewolf that would make herself proud.

Simple things.

At least now it seemed she had the chance of getting that.

Over and over and over again.

LOOP 1

At first, she thought she had to be dreaming.

Mainly because Enid embarrassingly didn't recognize anything was amiss for the first two loops. In her defense, the loop began and ended on a single Friday ahead of a rare three-day weekend off from school. And weekends at Nevermore were usually one of two things: repetitive or uninspired.

Not to say a weekend at a school for the supernaturally inclined was boring, but a school was still a school at the end of the day. Especially for a weekend so near the start of a new semester. The days on campus were filled with students trying to do as much as they could with their first stretch of true free time. Everyone was either still getting their bearings around campus or preparing for their first major tests in the weeks to come. Friends hung out, still riding the fading high from break, or they were doubling down on familiarizing their set routines for the rest of the year—typical student life.

Enid would describe herself as a typical student.

Did she take advantage of the long weekend to mainly catch up on sleep? *Yes*, but Enid was a growing werewolf who was still adjusting to everything that personal circumstance specifically entailed. It didn't help that since the semester had started, her mother had taken the role of calling her daughter almost every day to nose her way in on Enid's progress and mental state. That by itself was exhausting to manage for any sane person. So if she wanted to skip out on a long weekend of socialising and fresh gossip to finally have her mother off her back then Enid was perfectly okay with accepting that loss.

That first Friday, she chose to sleep in, refusing an invitation to town from Yoko, and only woke up when the cravings of lunchtime forced her out of the room. Then it was back to bed until dinner and a mini spa night with Thing as the dredges of sleep overtook her. On the day she thought was Saturday, Enid begrudgingly took up the invitation and spent the afternoon with Yoko downtown and did little else but walk for a bit and head back to the dorm to sleep. Her *not*-Sunday was spent in the library, comfortably napping and scarcely studying for a test she had that following week in class.

Uneventful. *Typical*.

It was far from Enid's fault that she failed to realize she had been thrust into the equivalent of a late-night made-for-TV movie plot.

It wasn't until she woke up on *not*-Monday, refreshed and ready to tackle her classes, that she realized something was terribly wrong. Only made more clear the moment Yoko barged into her room and asked if she wanted to go into town later for lunch. Something the other girl had already asked and done in the subsequent days before. The same tone, the same inflection, the same outfit.

It was a level above déjà vu and thus, Enid was trapped in her recurrent woe.

Enid had learned a few things:

- This was not some horrible dream. (No matter how much she wished it was.)
- The loop restarted at 11:45 PM every night.
- ~~Wednesday possibly~~
- Everything and everyone followed the same routine the entire day unless Enid directly interfered.
- There was nothing that could be done to influence any change for a future loop.
- Everything reset except her own memories.
- As far as she could tell, no one was trying to murder her or her friends. (Which was honestly the most relieving discovery, yet she remained vigilant.)
- ~~Wednesday was really~~
- No one else was experiencing this with her . (At least that she could tell.)
- It was exhausting trying to get someone to believe her .
- She was really glad her thing with Ajax fizzled out.
- ~~Wednesday maybe was a~~
- Enid was lonely.

She treated it as a game at first.

Because why wouldn't Enid take advantage of the apparent freedom she now had and not copy what so many teen movies told her was fun to do when the consequences of her actions had no bearing of punishment. So she started simple, doing what she thought a normal delinquent was capable of~~with~~ with some restraint, of course. She still had morals.

Simple. *Typical*.

Small acts of vandalism where no one would notice, trespassing in student restricted areas, and just being the most rule-abiding menace she could be. Though a line was drawn at venturing into the more hidden spots of Nevermore. Enid wasn't sure if death was something that could affect her, and she wasn't about to test the

theory. Especially with the secrets this school definitely still held in its mysterious depths.

An odd consequence Enid didn't expect was how each small act of rebellion ignited something invigorating within her. It was a powerful feeling. Not in the aspect of strength but of a release of apprehension. A dormant part of her inner wolf or some form of normal teenage development, maybe? Either way, it made her wonder if this was how her brothers felt all the time. She always used to think their rambunctious tendencies skipped over her, but maybe that wasn't totally true.

After that revelation, it was easier to let the little voice in her head take the reins and allow her to act more brashly, but since that type of behavior wasn't truly in Enid's nature, the spark quickly faded after a week, and she started to grow bored. Thankfully, no one reacted strangely or overtly weird to her antics, nor did she feel any scrutinized attention on her day-to-day delinquency. In fact, Enid was a bit disappointed regarding the security on campus with how unnoticed her contained teenage rampage went. Which, truth be told, was a blessing in disguise because as much crazy shit as she'd gotten into the past semester, her offbeat behavior did allow her to rule out any potential threat toward her.

A lack of psychotic murdering was a win in her book, but still begged the question of *what the hell was going on…*

For the next loop, she obsessively made notes on who, if anyone, had it out for her.

It ended up being a short list, which only made her irrationally wonder if she *should* have more enemies. Which then led to the illogical suspicion of her mother for a brief moment. That was a phone call Enid would not be repeating anytime soon.

The capability for someone able to manipulate time was already beyond anything Enid knew of what normal Outcasts were capable of. Then again, up until last semester, Enid didn't believe the

resurrection of a centuries-old homicidal pilgrim was something that could ever be possible. So maybe allowing for some suspension of disbelief was warranted.

Either way, Enid was at the end of her rope. Loops were passing by, and she was no closer to figuring out a way forward. A slow-growing sense of paranoia wasn't helping and only added to her frustrations. Thus started the enlistment of her friends to help solve her temporal conundrum and build some sense of stability in this new normal.

Much like how she approached her delinquency, simplicity seemed to be the safe bet: find a friend, plead her case, take notes. Enid learned two things with this method—how much her schoolmates trusted in Enid as a person and just how susceptible into believing the weird supernatural shit the Nevermore student body went through on the daily.

Ajax was her trial run—mainly to get the awkward tension out of the way.

It went as expected. Any good-hearted person, like Ajax, would do what they could to help a friend, but the complex situation of it all tripped him up in the end. While Enid appreciated his genuineness, she made the decision to avoid him in any subsequent loops. Even though he seemed fine after their breakup, Enid could see his forlorn gaze as they spoke and suspected it wouldn't be as simple as just being friends again. Plus, having an ex be the only person to know what was happening to her could send him a message she did not want to pile on top of an already stressful situation.

So it didn't make any sense why Enid then sought out Xavier at all.

He wasn't the type of guy she talked with or was ever around much while at Nevermore. Unless you counted the times he was around Wednesday—and that already put a bad taste in her mouth, for reasons that had absolutely nothing to do with Wednesday's focused attentions. Regardless, the choice was justified as a *'get the unfavorable ideas done with quickly'* and also because he had the

most consistent schedule to ambush. Which was to say he didn't do much.

Xavier was nice. He had no reason not to be cordial to her and vice versa, so it served Enid essentially as a true practice run for the future. A way to iron out what worked and what didn't when trying to explain her predicament. It took some convincing and a bit of trial and error to find the right wording to get him to believe her, but he did eventually in the end. And even offered a session with his dad to help. The implication of it was a bit too intimidating, so Enid politely declined for now, but the situation bolstered her confidence significantly.

The obvious trail to follow next was the queen siren herself.

Bianca was a strange anomaly to Enid. They'd never had a motive to directly interact if not for school reasons, and yet this larger-than-life figure at Nevermore now seemed inexplicably connected to her due to their association with one Wednesday Addams. They had even begun to hang out once the semester started, for reasons unknown to Enid. Contrary to Wednesday's judgment of character, Bianca, surprisingly, believed Enid right from the get-go.

She claimed that anyone that close to Wednesday was bound to get in some kind of unbelievable occurrence at some point. Enid didn't know what that said about Bianca or her angle, but having an influential siren so readily on her side couldn't have been a bad thing. And helpful too. Bianca asked the smart questions Enid was too distracted to ponder. Like what was she doing the days before the loops, and if she had any magical items hidden in her room for any reason. The questions went unanswered as Enid had no way of confirming any of them, so she left the loop satisfied and happy to know she had a quick ally if needed.

Invigorated by her interaction with Bianca, it was only right to approach the people she had actual genial connections with. Which was, unfortunately, a short list.

Yoko being at the top of it.

Her vampiric friend believed her quickly. Maybe too quickly if Enid ever stopped to think about it, but she should have expected no less. Vampires were basically hardwired to adapt to strange situations based on their long lifetimes of witnessing more life than anyone should. Ever helpful, Yoko claimed she'd heard of this kind of thing before, which elated Enid just as quickly as it brought her down. What started as a lead ended up being an embellished story made up by one of Yoko's distant cousins.

Enid did allow herself a good cathartic breakdown on her friend's shoulder after that reveal, so the loop wasn't a total loss. But Enid did take that hiccup as a sign.

A sign that led to Eugene.

Looking back, Eugene probably should have been the first person she went to. There was no hesitation with him. Enid could barely get the words out before the other boy was completely on board with whatever was needed. His enthusiasm honestly would have made the beginning loops less scary and stressful if she had him in her corner. On par with everyone else, Eugene couldn't do much to help her, but his enthusiasm and zeal were unmatched if not a little forceful. Enid made a note to herself to really thank him and make an effort to befriend him more if she ever got out of this time loop predicament.

Though Eugene's enthusiasm couldn't hold off the sad truth that even the brightest students at Nevermore had any clue what was going on with Enid or got her closer to breaking the looping days.

Enid needed something of an emotional reset before approaching the last people on her very short list…

Her brothers ended up being the perfect reset.

They didn't help, mainly because Enid didn't tell them anything, but there was something vaguely comforting about being in their presence even through this bizarre situation. A normal person would say it was because they were family, but Enid knew it was because they didn't care either way. Their behavior, while obnoxious, was supremely comforting. As much as she didn't relate to them for the majority of her life, they were still family. They had a bond, especially as werewolves, that nobody outside their pack would ever truly understand.

So it wasn't that much of a surprise to Enid when they invited her out to lunch. Sure, lunch may have turned into a mini food fight, but the comfort they exuded was more valuable than any progress on getting her out of these loops. Bit only slightly.

This whole situation was still a major problem and needed to be solved...which easily led her to Thing.

Thing, as sweet as he was, didn't take much convincing on her issue, but in what seemed like a repeating problem, couldn't offer much help aside from aiding in doing some research. The research ended up a dead end as Enid had no idea what to look for or where to even start.

Enid spent two loops brainstorming with Thing, though it did nothing but make abundantly clear what had to happen next. because that seemed to be the theme. Everyone was eager in their own way to help her, but no one was built to solve a complex mystery with the dedication it deserved. No one except the one person Enid was hesitant to approach, no matter how many loops had already passed.

Hesitant because while she had an idea of how school at Nevermore was going to progress, the insertion of Wednesday Addams into her life changed just about every trajectory she'd set for herself.

Hesitant because Enid finally got the cute boy she'd been crushing on throughout the school year, but he wasn't the one occupying the

majority of her thoughts after they all split once the semester ended.

Hesitant because Enid was nothing if not open to personal growth and learning new things about herself~~th~~ings that were fine and great and beautiful on average but felt strange and warped when she'd only just come to terms with the development and was immediately forced to repeat the same fifteen hours for an undetermined amount of time.

Hesitant because why did beautiful personal discoveries matter when the one person who surrounded them was forever stagnant in their own growth?

The entire world was at a standstill, and Enid's newfound attraction was left floundering.

Here's what Enid definitively knew about her roommate:

- Wednesday tolerated her presence more than she realized.
- Wednesday was a curious girl ~~and Enid may have let ego get in the way thinking that her curiosity also extended to Enid herself~~.
- Having Wednesday's attention was something to covet. ~~(Enid's charm and likability alone was enough to warrant at least some attention from someone who claimed wasnt interested in congeniality.)~~
- ~~Wednesday was really pretty but in a way that Enid seemed to notice it all the time now.~~
- Wednesday was her best friend ~~but in a way that Enid was disappointed to realize ended at that~~.
- Wednesday was her really pretty best friend ~~but in a way that, despite being darkness' incarnate, the other girl lit a spark in Enid's heart that burned brighter than the ebony black of night that suffused her side of the room at all times.~~
- Enid Sinclair maybe ~~definitely~~ had a crush on Wednesday Addams.
- Wednesday—

Enid pushed her notebook off her desk with a loud groan. Pen, paper, and other miscellaneous items clattered to the ground in the deafening silence of her dorm room. Head in hand, she bit her lip until the iron taste of blood spilled on her lips. She soothed it over with her tongue until the stinging faded, but the desired effect had already taken hold. That roiling, powerful spirit of the wolf inside her rumbled at the heightened bout of pain. t wasn't enough to warrant a wolf out, but Enid's stress levels were not helpful to the cause.

She was angryand that anger focused her mind in a way that helped her realize she'd wasted two weeks in this endless cycle. Y et she was no closer to regulating her own emotional state despite the infinite amount of time at her fingertips. t was that anger that made her realize she was truly stuck.

At the end of a rope, there was nothing else to really do except seek out Wednesday. B t the thought of being around her crush seemed more daunting a task than spending another Friday floundering in ambiguity.

The timer on her watch ticked by slowly.

The blinking clock face;a constant reminder of her own temporal woes.

She could give it a couple more loops…

Chapter End Notes

tll only get better from here Enid...maybe.

Thanks for reading!Please let me know what you think.

Woe Is Built With Consistency

Chapter Summary

> Enid, still stuck in a time loop, makes some bold choices and faces some consequences.

Chapter Notes

> Hey! We're halfway through *and* Wednesday finally arrives. That should be fun.
>
> All mistakes are my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

LOOP

An ages-old cloud of dust billowed around Enid's head as Yoko dropped a small stack of books onto the table in front of her.

"The librarian's in a mood today," Yoko grumbled. Her chair made a grating screech as it scraped across the floor as she settled into it. "These help?"

A halfhearted glance at the spines of the books read: *Threads of Time*, *The Fabric of the Cosmos*, *In Search of the Edge of Time*. The idyllic script of each title flaunted nothing but false hopes that an answer would be held in its pages.

Enid gave a distracted nod towards her friend, her mind otherwise occupied with the profundity of *circular chains of causality* and how that might help in ending her time loop situation.

Already three weeks had passed with no change to her new reality—not that Enid had been trying very hard to end it. In her defense, sixteen hours moved quickly when routines were broken, and every

wasted second not committed to breaking the loop racked her with debilitating guilt. It was especially debilitating when she chose to avoid her greatest potential asset against this ordeal every chance she got.

Did that make her a coward?

"I'm having a weird day," Yoko said with a groan, rubbing her temples in small circles.

"Ditto," Enid replied mechanically. At the end of the next table, to the right of them, was an old lamp. She quickly noted the frequency of its flickering and focused back on her book.

Flipping past another page of irrelevant, flagrant text became a kind of metaphorical tick of a doomsday clock floating above Enid's head. The shorter the back end of the book in her hands got, the more dread seemed to hang over her. This was the third book in four days she had read that referenced outrageous anomalies in the Outcast community, but unfortunately detailed nothing about time loops.

Yoko cleared her throat, and Enid realized with a start that her friend was waiting for her to speak. "Sorry, what's up?"

The other girl stared at her, concerned. "You all right?"

"Yeah? Why?"

She poked at the deep crease of wrinkles on Enid's forehead and leaned back in her chair, arms crossed, scrutinizing. "I don't get it. You said you've only been stuck for like three days."

Deep within whatever presence of mind her inner-werewolf rested, its force paced with agitation. Sharpened nails dug into the table, leaving shallow gouges in the old wood. "So?"

The other girl seemed not to notice. "Sooo, what are we doing here? Why are we in the library and why do you look like you're stressing

for any exam? You literally have infinite time to fuck around. That's basically vampire life 101."

Enid forced herself to shut her book. "Does all that make me an honorary fang?"

"Not up to me," she teased. "Gotta spend at least a week with immortality before I can initiate you."

Enid attempted not to cringe. "Right"…

"But I'm serious, the day is young. We can't spend an hour putting whipped cream in Kent's pillow or flipping all his furniture upside down?"

Enid leveled her friend with a look. "You know you have to forgive him eventually."

"According to you, now I never have to," Yoko smirked. Sharp fangs poked out of the corner of her lips. "His apology was shit and I can stay mad if I want."

"Whatever."

Yoko rested her chin on her hand, staring hard at Enid. "At least no one's trying to murder you."

"Allegedly."

"*Allegedly*," she echoed, then paused for a second. "Are you sure you don't want the Nightshade's help? There's a lot of books down there. Granted, it's mostly history and random Outcasts stuff, but I'm not sure even we've catalouged everything yet."

"Already tried. Takes too long to convince everyone to help search and I'm still skeeved out from the last time I had to be there." Enid full body shivered. "No, I'd rather exhaust every resource I have above ground before *willingly* going back down there."

"Fair ."

"Also, it' s not like we cant *all* be in a secret society," Enid mumbled, barely holding back a scoff.

Yoko cracked a slow smile, fangs now devilishly on display. A passing student stumbled back, witnessing the predatory look on her face, but before he could begin to lose his balance, Enid's hand was already there to steady and push him on his way.

"Are you still mad about that? Seriously , it wasnt up to me. Recruitment is kind of exclusive."

"*Exclusive.* Yeah, exclusive to just everyone in our friend group *except* me." She huf fed petulantly. "Whatever , Im not obsessing— Im over it."

"Are you?"

Ten seconds of Yoko's smug grin was all Enid lasted before the twitch in her eye gave out. "Y ou dont even *like* camping out." Colorfully manicured hands gestured in a flurry of fueled indignation. "And," she barked a laugh, " *amateur mixologist* ? Really? Y ou stole your cousin's vintage shaker and told everyone you were taking classes at the local community college. Amateur my ass."

"*Yeah*," Y oko drawled, letting her friend continue to vent her frustrations, "*definitely over it…*"

"Sorry . t' s just the second Ineed a secret society' s help with a problem, someone has definitely already died. So," she took a breath and said with saccharine sweetness, "thank you, Y oko, but Im gonna hold out as long as Ican and avoid that possibility from happening."

Yoko held her hands up in surrender and relaxed back in her chair , looking around the library for something new to occupy her attention.

Enid glanced again toward the nearby lamp, still flickering intermittently. The flashes of soft yellow light cadenced like a drum and her head buzzed in time with it.

There had to be something—something to explain all this.

Without an answer, Enid begrudgingly turned back to her book.

'…a misfiring of memory circuits. The most widely accepted theory is that it's the result of a momentary lapse in the synchronization of the brain's short and long-term memory systems. Essentially, the brain…'

Eyes unfocused, a trail of ink and paper bled through each page until Enid could no longer see a single word separate from the next. A haze drifted across her mind, tarrying her whirling thoughts to a numbing rest.

"Oh my god, Itotally forgot!" Yoko leaned forward conspiringly, unaware of the other girl's disposition. "You'll never guess what Divina told me about Kent."

Enid choked down her insensibilities. "You mean that he's sneaking a normie into his dorm? Yeah, that's a lie. A few stoners spread the rumor when Kent didn't throw a fencing match. It's dumb boy stuff."

"How did you know that?" Yoko pushed her sunglasses up and narrowed her eyes. "Wait, is this your time-traveling thing in action? That's so cool."

"*Not* time travel." A forced smile stretched easily across her face. "You forget, you're not looking at Nevermore's number one gossip blogger for nothing." Her smile twitched as she held it. A beat passed before Yoko seemed to drop the subject and start a conversation about something she did over the break. Enid exhaled softly. This was a topic she'd been privy to about a dozen times already so she let her friend's words wash over and distract her until...

"So what's the deal with you and Wednesday?"

Since these loops started it was not often Enid was caught off guard.

A strained whimper escaped her lips. "*What*?"

A perfectly manicured finger tapped against Enid's open notebook where she had absentmindedly written Wednesday's name in the margins over and over again.

Enid's stomach bottomed out. She held her breath. There was no excuse for this. Her pen had betrayed her, and now Yoko had her pinned in the corner like wounded prey.

"Something you want to tell the class?"

She shook her head meekly. "I don't know what you're talking about."

Out of the corner of her eye, it was easy to spot the way the ink smudged where writing Wednesday's name was used with more force than anticipated. The letters blended into her sparsely written notes about the principles of time until the carefully cultivated research looked like it was describing a spatial phenomenon in the name of *Wednesday Addams*.

Something akin to embarrassment kept her throat in a vice.

"You're seriously not gonna talk about it?" Yoko stared at her blankly. "That's all right. Keep your secrets. Not like I'm your best friend or anything. But I just want to say, *for the record*, I *knew* something was up after you suddenly broke up with Ajax over break. Guess that's my bad I didn't notice the heart eyes for your roommate."

She crumbled. "What *heart* eyes? If anything, they're *normal* eyes. Normal eyes to *normally* look at people~~-ro~~ommates included."

"I'd hand you a mirror if I had one," Yoko deadpanned.

Enid rested her head in her hands and groaned. "You can't tell her," she pleaded pathetically. "I still haven't figured out how to approach this thing with her."

"Okay, pause. In what universe did you think I'd go tell Wednesday? The novelty may have worn off, but that girl still scares me."

"It's not a novelty—"

Yoko held up a hand to Enid's face. "I don't need the lovesick lecture. You know what I meant."

"*Lovesick*—you're one to talk," she mumbled under her breath.

"But my god," Yoko continued, chuckling. "There's no way I would've ever predicted this. You're friendly with anyone but I guess you always loved a challenge."

The act of being seen was as troubling as it gave relief. A torrent of emotions fought against each other in Enid's chest. The most prominent of them, *fatigue*. "I can really do without all the teasing. Let's skip to the part where you tell me what I should do."

"Just kiss her."

There wasn't an adequately justified response to her friend's suggestion because that was just... "Are you crazy? She'd probably stab me in my sleep. I can't just do that."

"Why not?" Yoko leveled Enid with a bead of scrutiny. "Look, you didn't wanna talk about it, whatever. That's your deal. But you said you're stuck in a time loop. What that's telling me is you can practically do whatever you want. Now I'm not saying just plant one on her—use some *finesse*. What's the worst that can happen?"

"Did you not hear when I said *stab me in my sleep*?"

"Are you hearing what *I'm* saying? Talk to Wednesday," Yoko said simply. "Set a mood and go for it."

"Just go for it." Enid could almost laugh.

The absolute complexity of her roommate's personal qualities meant any suggestion made out to be simple was obviously set up as a hoax. Befriending Wednesday Addams, in and of itself, resulted from a series of intricate interactions made to wean away at the other girl's deceptively closed-off aura. *Just go for it* wasn't going to cut it in this case and Enid knew it.

Yoko nodded encouragingly. "Worst case scenario, you get rejected and she forgets anything ever happened. Sounds like a win to me."

"Except I'm the one left with rejection."

"And the *time* to get over it." Yoko frowned when Enid didn't react to her joke.

"What do you want me to do? Sweep her into my arms, say something cheesy, and kiss her?" She threw her hands up, exasperated. "I'm just a girl!"

"I don't understand the issue here. Did you have this problem getting with Ajax?"

"That's different." She grimaced, thinking of that time. "He needed a strong arm. Wednesday is…"

"*Is*?" Yoko gave her a strange look. "She's your roommate *and* your friend. Just go hang out with her."

"Hang out with her." She mulled the suggestion around in her head. It was simple. Typical. Nothing she hadn't done in the past. "I guess I can do that."

"My god, it's like it's your first day on Earth. You sure wolfing out didn't knock some stuff in your head?"

"Shut up, I'm leaving."

Enid gathered her materials together, glancing one more time at the lamp on the table. It was flickering brighter than before. Anticipation pulsed in her veins.

Yoko whined. "I thought we were getting dinner later?"

"You're on your own. I have a new planet to explore."

"Wait. Hold up." She tugged on Enid's sleeve as she stood. "Joking aside, you may know Wednesday, but I fear you're too close to this. Wednesday may *act* like a loner but we both know that's bullshit. The way you two hang around each other is proof enough of that. I get you can't see some stuff when blinded by love sickness, but not all of us are as unobservant."

"Meaning?"

"I'm just saying, maybe your feelings aren't as unrequited as you think." Yoko put her hands up in surrender when Enid's brow furrowed. "I know how stubborn you can be, so I'm not gonna try to convince you of it, but just take the risk. I think you'll be surprised."

"What are you? The Wednesday Addams whisperer? I take risks," she said indignantly.

"Yeah, sure, sure."

Enid flicked her eyes over just as the lamp on the table burned out with a loud popping noise. She waited for the librarian's grumble from the far side of the room to slip the stack of books into her bag and playfully sneer down at her friend.

"Don't eat the soup. Some upperclassmen found out his friend was cheating with his boyfriend and is making it everyone's problem."

Yoko mock saluted with an impish smile on her face. "Good looking out. Have fun with your dark cloud of sunshine."

Enid threw an obscene gesture her way as she left.

With an inkling of a next step and no specific destination in mind, Enid wandered towards Ophelia Hall.

First, taking the long way back to the building, already knowing to avoid an overenthusiastic group of students settled in the quad at this hour. Then, doubling back once she realized this route would run her into Ajax. Her brain was already buzzing after her talk with Yoko; there was no point in adding to it, especially if she was going to finally confront Wednesday.

Maybe…

Their dorm room was calm. Quiet.

The late afternoon sun shone through the window in a half-kaleidoscope of color. It cast long shadows of f the floor, heightening the stillness in the room. Not unexpected. Enid knew Wednesday was out by the lake at this time despite trying her hardest to avoid learning the other girl's schedule. So, of course it was the first one she inadvertently committed to memory.

Still, she was out of her depth.

While she knew every hour of Wednesday's schedule, Enid never took the leap to interact with the girl. It was as if a switch in the back of her mind had flipped the second she realized her greater feelings. This would be uncharted territory. Facing Wednesday was suddenly the most daunting action she could take, but avoiding her roommate like the plague no longer served a purpose other than staving off her own cowardice.

No more. Three weeks was time enough to stall.

Tried and true, phone in hand the easiest way to initiate contact, Enid texted Wednesday.

Their message thread was filled with short videos she'd sent to the other girl over break. Every video was aptly replied to with one-word responses, if there was a response at all.

'Can we talk?'

A second later, the melodic default ringtone of Wednesday's phone broke the silence of their room.

Enid groaned.

"Of course you wouldn't have your phone during the *one day* I'm doomed to loop for eternity. *Fantastic*," she hissed under her breath. Fishing the phone out from under a few discarded pages of schoolwork, Enid contemplated her next step.

"Whatever," she said to the empty room. "You're a big girl, Enid. It's like mom says, *there's no use crying to the moon when no one's around to listen.*"

The old adage, while certainly incorrect, instilled the slightest bit of confidence in her. It was a reminder of that supernatural capability inside her—no longer dormant. A reminder that she was tougher than appearances led one to believe. And while physical strength would do her no good in this instance, it gave her a sureness that she could face Wednesday.

Maybe…

The lake was quiet at this time, but Enid knew it was more due to her roommate's presence by the lakeshore than anything else. Wednesday's innate aura was a natural repellent for the average Nevermore student—which suited Enid's interests greatly. She'd rather not have an audience for the potential crash and burn that would surely follow.

It was like something out of a movie.

The clouds slowly parted as a ray of brilliant sunlight beamed down at just the right angle to cast the other girl in a grim swath of dark shadows. Wednesday's eyes rose to meet hers briefly across the shoreline. It was in that brief moment that Enid realized this would be the first meaningful interaction she'd have with Wednesday since being stuck in these loops.

Every step toward the lakeshore felt like sinking into mud. A weight in her chest turned like a rough stone, dragging her further down into it.

Voice strained, she called out, "Wednesday."

The girl looked over her shoulder in such stunning fashion that Enid swore that if this were a television show, some melodramatic pop song would start playing in the background. The thought of it almost made her giggle.

"I'm not to be disturbed." With eyes half narrowed, Wednesday spared a quick full-body scan of Enid and pursed her lips together in an instinctual frown. "I told Thing to guard the perimeter, but it seems he's run off. Useless."

Enid smiled privately to herself. She knew Thing snuck off around this time to raid the Hummer's workshop to make a lotion with their honey. He threw the stolen jar at her in fright the first time she caught him skulking.

While she loved Thing, it never hurt to have a bit of blackmail in her back pocket. One of the many traits she picked up from her roommate.

"Wednesday," Enid said again after a moment.

"Enid," she said coolly, fully facing her this time.

The sudden attention was both intimidating as much as underwhelming. Once her crush manifested, Enid had built

Wednesday onto this larger-than-life pillar of reverence. But this was *Wednesday*. Her roommate. The girl who didn't outright say she didn't like her birthday present to spare her feelings, then turn around to manipulate and lie about wanting a girls' night out.

Enid had to remind herself that Wednesday was just another person living her own unique circumstantial life, and they were lucky enough to revolve in each other's orbit.

A calmness settled over over as she smiled widely. "Howdy."

Already turned back to her work, Wednesday didn't spare another glance. "Make it quick, I'm—"

"You're performing a delicate operation that requires the *utmost* focus and attention. I know," she said, falling easily into their rapport. "Your calculations are off anyway. Your brother sent you the wrong specs." Enid never truly figured out what it was the other girl was supposed to be building, but she'd been privy to Wednesday storming back into their room in the evenings, fuming over Pugsly's *treacherous attempt on her life*.

Heeding the warning, Wednesday straightened up and backed away from the elaborate contraption, giving it a careful once-over.

She scoffed, apparently finding the issue. "If he did this on purpose, he's even more devious than I thought to give him credit for." Dark eyes turned to Enid suspiciously. "How did you know?"

Enid shrugged coquettishly. "Anyone could've figured it out just by looking. I'm sure you would've noticed eventually." There was absolutely no indication on Wednesday's face that she trusted her lie. "Fine. Would you believe *intuition*?"

"No."

"Rude. Then who's to say some of your genius hasn't rubbed off on me?"

Wednesday made a noise and brushed off the suspicion with a wave of her hand. "Did you need something?" Without looking back, she was already disassembling certain parts of the contraption while scribbling over its blueprints.

That pissed Enid off a little bit. Here she spent the last three-plus weeks trying to gather up courage, and here Wednesday was being blithely dismissive.

Back straight, Enid stood imposingly over the other girl. "Is my presence bothering you?" she asked, cocking her head slightly. When Wednesday wordless said *no*, Enid sat down next to her on the gravel. "Then, if I'm not bothering you, is it all right if we hang out today? You know, because that's what roommates do. We hang around each other."

Wednesday didn't look up from her schematics, still marking corrections and drawing furiously in the margins. "What's wrong?"

"Why does anything have to be wrong?" she asked defensively. "Maybe I just want to hang around my best friend. Maybe I just want your company. Is that so bad? I know the thought of human connection makes your skin crawl—"

"It does."

"Well, you should start thinking that you're someone worth being around. I want to be," she finished lamely. "*Around you*, I mean."

Wednesday was quiet for a minute, methodically reworking bits of the machine. "I didn't say no." She glanced at the other girl from the corner of her eye. "Do what you like."

Pleased at crossing one major hurdle, Enid took her small bout of confidence and smiled eagerly at her roommate. It went unnoticed, but she felt better for it.

But since Thing is missing, at least make yourself useful. Hold this part here."

Wednesday gently pulled Enid's hand to every needed placement as she continued to dismantle the contraption. Internally freaking out, Enid dutitifully let the other girl guide her hands and made an effort not to comment on it.

Which was another thing~~all~~ the recent touching.

Among the expected changes that came with a new semester , something was noticeably different about Wednesday. Despite her usual platitudes on the act of *affection*, Wednesday's stance seemed to have shifted, at least when it came to Enid.

At first, she had chalked it up to the other girl finally embracing their best friend status, but the drastic difference in physical contact was too unbelievable for it to be just that. It was a hand on her shoulder when her back was turned. A lithe finger touching Enid's wrist when Wednesday wanted to show off something. An innocent leg bump against hers if they sat together during meal times. And a host of other examples.

Enid's heart didn't know peace.

Being a newly outed werewolf, Enid had set expectations when coming back to school. Wednesday's apparent shift in demeanor was not one of them. Her roommate seemed to almost welcome her presence as of late. Though there was still a time limit to the other girl's tolerance. Enid had worn her down to abide her presence for about three hours before she'd eventually turn her head, and Wednesday would just vanish.

But Yoko's last words of advice floated back to the forefront of her mind. If she thought for just a moment that her feelings could be reciprocated, then maybe Wednesday's odd behavior wasn't completely unfounded.

f anything, Enid would let herself live in this fixed attention for as long as she was able.

"Are you and Ajax well?"

Abruptly broken from her musing, Enid failed to realize they were already walking from the lake.

She sputtered. "*What*?"

"I saw you two last week in the quad after dinner," Wednesday explained evenly. "There was an obvious tension between the two of you. I know you value relationships of that nature so I was only curious. For your sake," she added with only the slightest bit of haste extended over her words.

"Last week?" It was hard to think that far back. Enid didn't remember there being any tension. Ajax was only delivering a message from a teacher. *Strange that she thought otherwise…* "Right. Oh, no, he and there really isn't anything going on. I broke it off a while back. He's not really someone I see myself with anymore." The explanation choked her throat as she felt the words bubble out before she could stop them. "I actually like someone else. I couldn't stand to string him along anymore. It felt unfair. To both of us."

"Oh?"

While she may know her friend better than most. Reading the face of Wednesday Addams should have come with a manual. Every subtle facial tick was a new emotion. Every smooth quirk of her eyebrows ranged in definition from interest to irritation. Every quiet breath said more than her prolific vocabulary ever could.

"Yeah," Enid said quietly. "It's new. Kind of."

Her arms folded over her chest. "I assume so since you haven't been wrecking my ear about them every night." There was a glimmer in her eye. "Or maybe because you think I won't approve? If that's the

case, dont worry yourself about it. Ive come to trust your , albeit peculiar at times, judgement."

Enid had to laugh, but composed herself quickly enough to mask it as a cough. "Your approval holds more sway than you think. Honestly, Ive been a little intimidated to say it out loud to anyone." She looked at her friend and swallowed hard. "You can ask. If you want."

She wasnt sure where this boldness was coming from. It certainly wasnt from the way her heart was hammering in her chest.

But Wednesday moved on and suggested they head to dinner. The topic was pointedly dropped.

Now in their dorm, Enid could feel the visceral weight of the loop's approaching end. The thought of it gripped her chest tightly. She didnt wanna give this up.

Her first day with Wednesday after a month of senseless avoidance.

Though something inside her knew why shed waited this long.

Minuscule heartbreak. Enid's attraction would grow, but Wednesday would never live beyond this moment. Sixteen hours was insignificant. It was pointless;painful.

They got ready for bed separately as routine dictated, but Enid was slow to move. Every step, every movement was weighted with every tick of the clock that passed.

Rooted to the middle of their room—the invisible divide between them, Enid stood completely despondent. If Wednesday took notice, she didnt say anything, but Enid wished she would. At least then it wouldnt make these last moments so peripheral.

"It cant end like this,"she said. Barely a whisper . Barely a breath.

There was the slightest shift in the air. An unfamiliar euphoria to Enid, who spent endless days memorizing and anticipating the interactivity of every hour. She was caught floating on an edge between an unknown cliffside and a depthless plunge into an abyss.

It was fear.

Vulnerability.

The watch on her wrist beeped, signifying ten minutes until reset. In an instant, the room became tense with apprehension.

Blue eyes locked with dark brown. No waver in her voice. "You *should* ask me, Wednesday."

Wednesday's face remained neutral, betraying nothing. No need for clarification, she only asked, "Why?"

A step over the threshold. "Because I think I've been wasting time for no reason."

"I don't follow."

Another step. "You know how people say it's easy to live without consequences? I've lived it and I can say without a doubt it's not easy. Everything feels like a mistake. Every moment blends into the next. Rules, routine, expectation—it doesn't mean anything. It's exhausting. And at this point, I'm just tired."

Wednesday only blinked at her, so Enid continued before she lost her nerve.

"And maybe that's the only reason why—why I'm even considering this right now."A few more steps.

A blanket of careful recognition flashed across Wednesday's face. Panic seized Enid's chest at the sight of it.

“*Ilike you, W ednesday*,”she abruptly confessed, attempting to push past the vice-like grip of panic.

The admission almost fell flat. Desperation coated each syllable, flavoring it to seem less than sincere. Enid bit her bottom lip, waiting for the other girl to respond. The panic bubbled harder when another minute slowly ticked by as they stared at one another in surreal silence.

‘m really of f the deep end here,”Enid whispered when the silence was too much. “Can you say something?”

Wednesday continued to look at her wide-eyed.

Through her silence, the words seemed to just manifest themselves. Enid had no means or willpower to stop them. ‘m sorry if this is completely insane. t just feels like ve been free-falling for weeks, and Idont know what to do with myself anymore.”The endlessness of the loops. The repetitiveness of them. How no one but her would ever understand. t all felt like shackles of perpetuity . “Y ou wont remember this, and Idont know what Ihave to lose at this point.”

The bizarrely worded admittance seemed to shock W ednesday back into animation. Her voice was a harsh rasp. “What do you mean?”

Enid checked her watch. A couple of minutes until the end of the loop. “Y ou wont remember this”she whispered moreso to herself. “And ‘m not sure if that makes this worse.”

She reached for Wednesday’s hand, which came without resistance. Then pulled her by the waist and leaned her face down slowly. She felt the other girl’s hands reflexively grab her forearms, and Enid stopped a few inches before their lips touched.

Arrested by the action she so desperately wanted, Enid lost her nerve.

She couldnt move. They were locked in that position. Chest to chest. Wednesday's shallow breaths tickled against her cheek.

Time stilled, and Enid swore Wednesday leaned up the rest of the way and kissed her.

t was a small simmer of heat and passion and too many emotions that left her dizzy.

Wednesday kissed her, and it was barely long enough to initiate any significant fervour, but Enid's heart leapt up in her throat.

Kissing Wednesday, as brief as the act was, was different from kissing Ajax. With him, there was a subtle thrill in the pit of her stomach like the successful hunt of an elusive prey. When they were together, it was easy. Typical. Her pulse quickened. Her body responded. t satisfied a part of her mind that needed the risk of a hunt without a wolf to guide her. Her ex-boyfriend was a risk, but a safe one.

Kissing Wednesday was none of that.

t almost felt one-sided in the same way that you couldnt control a fire once you've let it burn. t scorched and caught on anything it could light until your entire being was lit aflame, left to burn for an eternity.

Whatever dormant embers resided within Enid in her own cold and lifeless eternity, caught a spark the moment her lips touched Wednesday's.

The alarm on her watch went off.

LOVE

h her limited life experience, Enid had never had the pleasure of bungee jumping, but she imagined that what she was currently

experiencing wasn't too far off.

A moment of freefall before the taught cord ripped you back into the air and down again. Adrenaline coursing through your veins to an almost painful degree as your brain attempted to process all the information flying past it to reassure yourself that you weren't actually dying.

It was certainly an experience to wake up to.

Something low in her back gave a loud pop from the way she rocketed up from her bed. A wave of dizziness crashed over her senses as the resolute pounding in her head slowly subsided. Adrenaline rushed through her body like a broken river off the side of a mountain. It took a solid minute to calm herself and take stock of her surroundings…

The same bright shining sun. The same melodic birdsong. The same distant shouts of students on their early morning workouts. The same imposing shadow of her roommate that loomed over her bedside. Wednesday staring at her with veiled malcontent—

"Wait. That's not right," Enid said out loud.

Stock still, their faces mirrored each other's wide-eyed shock.

Then Wednesday's hand connected with Enid's cheek.

It didn't sting as there wasn't any proper force behind the slap. Enid could even guess the other girl wasn't even trying to hurt her, just by the look of surprise on Wednesday's face that her hand had moved at all. One could even argue that the intention of the slap was more meaningful than the actual strength put behind it. While Wednesday was surprisingly nimble and lithe, she was not incredibly strong, and compared to Enid's natural werewolf physique, it was laughable to compare.

Reflexively holding her cheek, Enid asked in a shaken whisper, "You remember?"

Wednesday's usually affectless face was a mixture of the barest showing of regret and confusion. Her words were slow and articulated. "What just happened?"

All the air in Enid's lungs released in one abating breath. "You remember?"

It took a second for Wednesday to respond. Her jaw clenched and relaxed as if trying to remember how to work. "Enid," she said carefully, "what is going on?"

"Am I dreaming? *Did it finally end?* She felt lightheaded. "Have I finally lost my mind? Are you a figment of my imagination?"

"No."

"Prove it," Enid said, deadly seriously.

With a start, Wednesday seemed to remember herself. All at once, her posture and visage fell back into their usual impassive stolidness. "Prove I'm real?"

"No, you're right. You can't. That's silly." Enid waved a dismissive hand in the air. "Maybe I'm a figment of *your* imagination.

"Or we're all phantoms in the dream of some vindictive demon," Wednesday added flatly.

"You think so?"

The other girl shrugged. "Suffering should always be equally distributed."

"That's kind of liberating," Enid said matter-of-factly.

"Suffering?"

"Equal distribution. Makes the scary stuff less intense when everyone experiences it. But then I guess what would be the point if everyone—"

"*Enid*." A muscle in her jaw tightened. "As much as I'd like to discuss the various facets of individualistic agony with you, I think something holds a bit more precedence."

"Right." Enid took a shaky breath, centering herself. "Do you really remember?"

There was a slight uptick of frustration in her tone. "I don't understand the implication. I remember what I know."

"*You remember what you know,*" she echoed. Wednesday remembered.

Elation and joy and an amalgam of different emotions she didn't have a name for welled in her heart.

She wasn't alone anymore. Something changed.

The thought that this could all be an awful dream played at the edge of her mind, but the evidence in front of her in the small figure of macabre abundance that was Wednesday Addams meant something *had* changed. All because—

"Can I kiss you again?" Enid leaned forward almost eagerly.

"No, Enid!" Wednesday flinched backward. An uncharacteristic stutter fell from her lips. "Tell me what the hell is going on, or I'll skin the polyester fur off your unicorns and hang their mangled bodies off the balcony."

Enid couldn't help it. She cried.

Hot tears flowed freely and swiftly down her cheeks.

Stuck in this time loop alone for so long took more of an emotional toll than she thought. Day after day, waking up not knowing if this loop would be the one to free her or end with no outcome. Living with the eternal promise of death that loomed with every ticking second. The mental exhaustion of repeating the same sixteen hours. The anxiety that came with explaining her situation to those she trusted, just to have a few precious minutes where she didn't feel trapped in her own world. Then hopelessly reading books that held no answers after realizing that memorizing patterns had become second nature. Leading to the defeated understanding that nothing shocked her anymore.

Except this moment.

Wednesday obviously wasn't expecting the tears. She stared uneasily at Enid crying for a moment, then glanced over her shoulder for Thing. He was in the far corner of her side of the room, already rummaging through her stuff for a handkerchief. He skittered over to Enid's bed and laid it out next to her , giving a comforting pat on her shin.

Still sobbing, Enid took the offer and attempted to wipe her eyes to no effect as fresh tears rapidly replaced them. She hated ugly crying. It drained her energy fully and left her stuck with an annoying headache and an itchy face for the rest of the day.

It took a few minutes, but after finally calming down enough to open her eyes, there Wednesday was, rigidly perched at the corner of her bed, still as a statue.

"I wouldn't skin your animals," W ednesday said stiffly. "I was only embellishing."

"I don't care about the stuf fed animals." Enid hiccuped and wiped a few more errant tears. "Do you really remember the last loop?"

"Loop?"

"When we kissed."

"We kissed yesterday, yes."

That shocked her for some reason to be said so bluntly out in the open almost made it real, *even though it totally was*. Because it was, in fact, a decision and action that Enid had consciously contributed to. Not something that only existed in her mind or memory, but an actual truth that Wednesday's direct confirmation meant they both equally shared in.

Both of them…

She kissed Wednesday. She really did that. And now Enid was finally privy to something she thought impossible for the last month.

Consequences.

She sat straight up. "Oh my god. I *kissed* you!"

"You did"…

"Oh my god, you really remember."

"Enid," her voice was veiled with rising frustration, "patience is not something I share with the living. Tell me what is going on this instant."

With maturing levity, Enid felt a small smile start to curl at the ends of her lips while looking at Wednesday. Her roommate who knew—who remembered. The girl who now made this strange ordeal less daunting because there was no one Enid trusted more than her.

So she told her. Everything.

There was little to be more grateful for than Wednesday's temperless demeanor in this moment. She was able to talk freely, unconcerned with any sort of judgment, at least externally, from the other girl.

Wednesday took it in and digested the information with the rapid speed of someone with only her level of intelligence could. "I'm sorry I slapped you," she finally said.

"I barely felt it," Enid replied dismissively, eager to get to the point.

The blasé response seemed to vex Wednesday for some reason. "How long have you been in this loop?" Her eyes flitted about their dorm room, as if an obvious example would manifest itself to reveal that Enid wasn't lying.

The innocent question threw Enid for a turn. Any sort of mental counter running in her head had been abandoned shortly after the first few days, when it seemed like there was no end to the temporal trap. An inaccurate calculation of days was all she could manage.

"A few weeks, maybe?"

"*Weeks*?"

The subdued but still profound concern, at least in terms of Wednesday's emotional output, thrilled something deep in some ascient part of Enid.

Too stirred up to finally have another aware soul with her, Enid didn't catch Wednesday's slight change in demeanor. The way the recognition after her confession fell on the other girl's face. Shown only by the slightly more pronounced downturn of her lips from the normal frown that she sported.

"But you're here now, so we can figure this out together," Enid said excitedly, unable to stop the bubbling rant. "It's a little weird at first remembering everything when no one else does, but now we have each other. And you're super smart, so it'll be easy to get used to. I hate to say it, especially with how nice everyone was, but starting over from scratch every day with other people was kind of getting on my nerves."

"People can be disappointing," Wednesday agreed.

"Maybe in the real world, sure, but in here, all I *have* are people… even if they forget. And whatever, if I'm being too forward, but knowing you have a problem engaging with others I still hope that you'll at least help me"…

"You're not *people*, Enid. And now that it appears we are in this together, it would be incredibly stupid to work apart."

Enid sighed after a moment, her head abundant with possibilities now that she had Wednesday. Then she frowned. "How do we manage to get involved in all the more than weird shit that goes on here?"

"Incredible luck," Wednesday said, delighted.

She couldn't even be mad at Wednesday's enthusiasm for fucked up situations espeically when she was the best person for the job.

They shared a pleasant bit of silence between them. Both reconciling with their new normal in their own way.

"Well, come on," Enid said. "There's no use in sitting here. We should probably take it slow today." There was a lot they could do, and Enid was overwhelmed with the potential. "I'll get you caught up on what the routine of the day is for everybody, and we can go from there. Easy and slow."

Wednesday followed dutifully without comment.

It was a bit of a show-off moment for Enid. Almost like she was making her own kind of special magic predicting the future, so to speak. Wednesday was the ever observant secondary.

This was easy. Simple.

No expectations.

Mainly because they didn't talk about the kiss or anything related to it, but it was always there in the back of the conversation or in the corner of their eyes when they happened to look at each other. It existed in the rush of heat when they accidentally brushed against each other's sides.

It could've been all in Enid's mind, but even she could see that Wednesday was a bit more jumpy than usual, which wasn't saying much, but Enid knew her roommate well and could only hope she'd be affected by their kiss as much as her. If only to wonder if it would happen again.

If the overwhelming anxiety in her chest didn't bubble so violently, maybe she would've noticed the almost relaxed expression on the other girl's face throughout the day. How her normal irritability seemed extremely mellowed out.

By the end of the day, Wednesday hadn't made many comments aside from a few simple clarifying questions, but Enid could see the wheels spinning in her mind as she took in everything shown to her.

It almost felt like they were on a date. Walking the campus. Observing the scenery. Silently enjoying the other's company.

It was everything to Enid.

LOOP

Enid couldn't remember the last time she woke up feeling this invigorated. The knowledge of another loop passed no longer felt as daunting when the experience was shared.

"Morning," she called from her bed with hesitant enthusiasm. "Sleep all right?"

Wednesday's curious stare surveyed her surroundings before thoughtfully inspecting her hands. "Odd"…

"What is?"

"The day has restarted, but my body feels completely rested despite not technically sleeping. Yet neurologically, it feels as if no time has passed."

"Right! Isn't it great?" "It's seriously the only thing I've been thankful for. Especially on the hard loops."

"Hard?"

"Mentally." Enid gestured with her hands in a wide circle around her head. "My whole world's been *tilted*, you know? Trust me, it'll get to you soon enough."

Wednesday nodded absentmindedly. "Seeing as you haven't been driven to some form of psychosis, I found that doubtful, but I'll heed your expertise."

Enid preened a bit at being called an expert in a situation that should have been a stress-inducing nightmare—not that it wasn't at its core.

"So we have about sixteen hours, give or take. What do you wanna do?" She clasped her hands together excitedly. "I know the first few loops can be a little discouraging. It's kind of like having infinite time at your fingertips, and that can make decision-making a little intimidating, but that's why I'm here. Maybe you wanna try something you've never done before or sneak into an off-limits part of campus—even though that's never stopped you before. All I'm saying is I'd be up for it. Heck, I've probably done some of the things that you may decide to do. The world is your oyster."

Wednesday looked over at her incredulously. "As tempting as your offer is, I refuse to be trapped in this sorry excuse of a movie trope. We waste no time. I need to know all the information you've uncovered about these time loops."

"Yeah, of course." Enid nodded slowly, a bit dumbfounded. Right down to business. Should've expected that." She chuckled awkwardly. "My bad, that's on me. Been so long since I've been around someone I can actually make a plan with"…

Wednesday, surprisingly, seemed to consider that. "Apologies, was there something you wanted to do?"

"No! No, no, no." What shocked Enid wasn't the fact that Wednesday apologized or that she was so readily willing to set aside her own plans; it was the way she looked at Enid. Patient. Contrite. Mindful. It was a clear example of growth. Something Enid had taken for granted in the last month. "I'm really okay following your lead. Just wanted to make sure any impulses you may have had were sated. Infinite time and all that."

"Impulsivity can be regulated once I understand our situation better. For all we know, there's a time limit on this."

"Trust me, it's all I've thought about." She grimaced, then smiled. "This is so exciting! It's like we're detectives solving a mystery."

They found their way to a small, unused classroom. The windows were shuttered with old, decaying wood, giving the interior an eerie sort of vibe.

"Wow, this room is so—"

"Lovely." There was the slightest smirk on Wednesday's face as she took it in.

"Not the word I would've used." Enid shuddered as a cold draft blew from seemingly nowhere.

"Enough gawking."

Wednesday stood at the back of the room with an old, graying chalkboard meticulously writing out several details Enid had

previously conveyed to her. Taking the hint, Enid sat dutifully at one of the desks, waiting to be addressed.

The bright afternoon sun shone sporadically through the rotting slats of wood, painting Wednesday in a broken checkered pattern of light as she walked in a steady circle around Enid. Discerning dark brown eyes quietly scrutinized her from forehead to feet and back again—like prey stalking predator. There was something in those eyes that made Enid squirm—an agitation in her blood that wouldn't dampen.

Wednesday stopped in front of her desk. "Tell me what you remember."

Enid swallowed hard, forcing the warring impulse down. "Is this an interrogation? You know I don't do well under pressure like this."

With narrowed eyes and a satisfied smirk, Wednesday placed her hands on either end of the desk. "It's not an interrogation, but I can frame it as such if you like. Whatever you're comfortable with. Though I don't have any of my instruments."

An involuntary image of Wednesday playing the cello flashed through her mind before correcting itself with instruments much more deadly and sharp. "No, that's fine. What do you wanna know about the loops? I'm an open book."

"First, everything before. We should establish a working timeline." She pulled away from the desk. "Do you remember what you were doing last week? Did you change your routine at all? Talk to anyone you normally don't? Did you touch some magical artifact? Approached by a stranger or friend alike that seemed off?"

For a split second, something compelled Enid to lie. That fearsome unknowing if having Wednesday with her was not just an illusion. That this just happened to be some idyllic dream she'd wake from in the next second and come to realize that nothing had changed and she was still alone.

One questioning look from the other girl dispelled that thought.

"Maybe, no, no, not that I know of, and no," Enid answered plainly, then sighed. "I've been with you. We had school. I was in class. Listen, I've been in these loops longer than you. Obvs. it's hard for me to even remember what that week was for me."

"Why?"

She shrugged. "I stopped counting how many days passed. It was getting too depressing. I can't make notes. It all just disappears. All I remember now *is* the loops. Plus, I already went over all of this with Bianca. It's impossible to say I have evidence, but so far, there's nothing really saying I caused this. As far as we concluded, this whole thing is probably some *un*natural phenomenon."

"Pity we'll have to approach this differently then." Wednesday averted her eyes and turned her back to Enid, shoulders rigid. "You've been talking with Bianca a lot lately."

"I have? Well, yeah, I guess," she answered without thinking. "I mean, we're not really friends if that's what you're implying, but— wait. How do you know that?"

Wednesday didn't answer for a long moment. "You merely seemed distracted as of late with your mother's incessant pestering. I was… curious. Since I know something about parental vexation, I thought— well, it doesn't matter. But it seemed you were only meeting up with Bianca and the vampire one so I left the matter alone."

Enid's jaw was on the floor. "Oh my god," she cooed. "You were totally worried about me! You should've just talked to me."

Wednesday merely gave a mild shrug of her shoulders. "You said it yourself. A friend doesn't have to ask. If it were truly something *totally monumental*, as you say, then you would've approached me. Plus, I had Thing watching you."

The way Wednesday didn't catch her eyes sent a merry thrill through Enid. She clapped her hands together. "Noted for the future."

Enid didn't have the courage to tell her she was talking to Bianca before the loops happened, specifically *about* Wednesday. Not in so many words, but more in the topic of having feelings for someone who can be hard to trust emotionally. This was back when Enid was still a bit unsure of her burgeoning attraction for her roommate. Bianca was surprisingly empathetic to her plea, though they'd only just started talking before the loops took hold, so there wasn't much help sought from her. It was surprising that Wednesday even knew about that.

Then again, she was increasingly surprised by a lot of things Wednesday had been doing recently.

Lifting her head, Enid didn't realize that the other girl had reapproached her desk. In all her close-up up gloomy glory was Wednesday's face, not but a few inches away, watching her.

Enid involuntarily yelped but was frozen to her seat. "Oh." Wednesday didn't flinch.

Neither moved away from the other. Like the moment before they kissed, Enid could feel the other girl's breath along her cheek. Her heart stuttered madly against her chest.

There was the slightest bit of pressure on Enid's arm as they continued staring at each other. Then a bite of cold as Wednesday's hand loosely gripped the area of her wrist where the uniform's sleeve ended. Enid did everything not to move a muscle in her arm.

"Have you attempted dying?"

The question broke her out of whatever spell she'd been caught in. "Excuse me?"

Wednesday looked at her with that familiar glint of seriousness that unsettled anyone who witnessed it without fail. Like she was one affirmative away from selling Enid's body to science, except it would just be Wednesday, and she'd probably still be alive.

"You said we repeat the loop at a quarter to midnight. Have you found any significance in that? Why not midnight?" Wednesday mumbled to herself as if trying to navigate a puzzle. "Is that the only way to reach the end of a loop? Have you tried anything else?"

"Like what?" She didn't like the look in Wednesday's eyes.

"As I asked—could death be an automatic do-over?"

"I haven't tried…"

"The sci—"

"And I don't want you to either!"

Wednesday hummed and searched for something in Enid's eyes for a moment, then shook her head disdainfully, not finding whatever it was. "Fair enough. I'll admit the risk is too great being the only two aware entities. Though," she paused, "we could find a test subject."

Atop a nearby desk, completely forgotten, was Thing. He shrank back from Wednesday's piercing gaze. "Have you helped her at all?" Her biting tone sent him into frenzied signing, which Enid hurriedly interrupted.

"He's actually been really helpful the times I've gone to him!" In a quick bout of boldness, she gently grabbed Wednesday's face with her free hand and guided the girl's gaze back. "And we're not killing him either!"

Wednesday seemed to truly contemplate that action. "*Fine.* But we shouldn't dismiss the potential."

"Call me crazy, but I really want to avoid anyone dying. It's like the one thing I've been proud of that hasn't happened this entire time." She let her hand fall from the other girl's cheek. It may have been a trick of the low light, but Enid swore Wednesday's head turned slightly, chasing after it before righting herself.

"Now you're just taking the fun out of it. I'm sure I could convince at least one of our classmates."

"Eugene is off limits!" Enid insisted, already knowing where Wednesday's mindset was heading.

"No one else?"

"Wednesday!"

"Fine." Wednesday finally released Enid's wrist and murmured to herself. "Erratic pulse. Temporal side effect or other stimuli?"

"Are you serious?" She sputtered as blood rushed to the spot on her wrist where its heat had been stolen. "You were just taking my vitals?"

"What else?"

She bit the inside of her cheek until it hurt, staving off any negative reaction. "I'm not some lab experiment."

"Technically, we both are."

"At least tell me what you're doing when you're doing it."

"I'm just trying to keep an active record of our essential body functions."

Enid laughed without mirth. "I give up." She prostrated herself over the desk. "Do what you want with me."

"The dramatics are unnecessary . Youll be thankful Im being so thorough."

"*Thorough…right*."Enid sent her a look. "Y ou know, if you wanted to hold my hand, you could just say so."

"Noted. Let' s move on."

She gasped. "Oh my god, you totally wanted to hold my hand!"

"T ake the win, Enid,"W ednesday deadpanned.

Enid smiled privately to herself despite the emotional whiplash. Wednesday Addams was not an easy one to read, and she wouldnt have it any other way.

"Im hungry ,"Enid whined.

The sun had fully set hours ago, and the two of them were still holed up in the dingy classroom. Wednesday had written out the most detailed timeline she could muster from the information Enid had provided.

"Y ou can eat later. The human body can go at least three days without any caloric intake. You can last sixteen hours."W ednesday subtly rolled her eyes when another of Enid's loud whines cut through the room. "T aking this day to focus was necessary. Ineeded to know everything so that we would be on the same page intelligence-wise. Irefuse to waste weeks of my life trapped in—"

"Hey , that's not fair,"she cried. "I had no one to help me—anyone that remembered at least. *And* Im the one who had to figure everything out first. Youre lucky you have me. Do you know how hard it is to explain time loops to our friends over and over and over again? Im just a girl!"

Wednesday gave her a strange look. "No, and I refuse to go down that avenue. Which is why today was necessary. If you stop complaining, I promise not to deprive you of food again."

"Thank you." Enid glanced at her watch. "Well, we have five minutes left. I don't know if you've felt it, but aside from the overhanging impending nightmare, these loops are kind of cathartic."

"How so?"

"You get to try things you never would have normally because of fear holding you back."

Wednesday scoffed. "Fear never holds me back."

"All right," Enid said, daringly. "Then what's something you've always wanted to do but couldn't because of morals or whatever?"

The answer was quick. "Cannibalism."

"Oh..."

"That was a joke."

Enid stared at her roommate wearily. "I love that you're making jokes, but we need to work on your delivery. Intonation is key to healthy conversation and the art of landing jokes. I never know when you're being serious."

"That's intentional. I'm always serious."

"Now that's just contradictory."

"I'm trying to focus, Enid."

"Time is almost up." She stepped up to Wednesday and smiled gleefully. "There's nothing to focus on. Seriously, what's something you've always wanted to do?"

"Nothing we'd be able to replicate at school. Honest," she added when Enid gave her an exasperated look. There was a beat of silence before she spoke again. "And you?"

"What?"

"You haven't made another *attempt,* so I assume your catharsis is fully sated?"

"Huh?"

Wednesday didn't elaborate, and the question hung between them until the loop ended, hunger forgotten.

LOOP

Call it werewolf intuition, if there was such a thing, but Enid knew this loop felt unfamiliar. Which was not a feeling someone stuck in a time loop necessarily desired unless it meant freedom from it..

It started typical enough.

Yoko barged into her dorm and was kindly escorted out, Thing offered a spa morning to kick off the weekend, and Eugene was specifically avoided as they made their way to breakfast.

Typical. Nothing in the routine had changed.

The unfamiliarity Enid felt came from Wednesday.

From what Enid could tell, there was nothing particularly different about the other girl. Wednesday woke with the usual chip on her shoulder and breezed through their recently established morning memory check-in. But something was just off about her.

Fortunately, Enid, noting the day, expected this and was prepared for it.

"Do you want to chill out today?" she innocently asked W ednesday over breakfast.

"I always operate at subthermal temperatures," W ednesday said.

She cracked a small smile. "Okay , I'll give that one to you. It was actually kind of funny."

"Thank you. And no. There will be no *chilling*. We need to find a way out of this infernal time loop. We don't have time for dalliances."

"I'd argue we have all the time in the world for dalliances."

Wednesday spared her a glance over her coffee. "I'd laugh if I had the capacity for it."

"I'll take it!" Reaching across the table, Enid tapped the top of the other girl's hand. Wednesday's unnatural frigid body temperature was prickly against her finger. "But I'm also being serious. Y ou've been in this for about a week now. That's usually the breaking point in my experience."

"Has it only been a week? Strange how meaningless time becomes when the consequence of it is avoided. Though if I have to deal with Eugene pestering me about my actions every day for eternity, then that statement isn't quite true. So maybe you're right."

"I am?"

"W e can *chill* by throwing Eugene in the lake today."

"Absolutely not! W e don't throw our friends in the lake."

"Says you."

"Says the greater society in which we live. Says the basic rules of friendship. No throwing."

"I've never read these rules," W ednesday mumbled.

"They exist. Anyway, I just wanted to point out that it's not a bad idea to take it easy once in a loop. Though, by all accounts, you're handling this way better than I was. I got so desperate, I called my mother."

Wednesday's eyebrow raised. "That is true desperation," she said solemnly.

"Right! Can't believe I was that low." Enid shook her head. "But what I mean is you survived the week and didn't have a breakdown. Give yourself some slack."

Seemingly not heeding her advice, Wednesday stood up and began clearing her area. "A week in these loops is a week too long," she said shortly. "I appreciate you looking out for me, but we are simply built different. That's nothing to say about your gene pool, of course. I've met your family, and you turned out rather well."

"Thank you?" Enid was sure there was a compliment in there somewhere.

"Regardless, I have an experiment I'd like to get back to."

"Please don't say you're still fermenting that gross hand."

Wednesday remained silent.

"Wednesday! The literal only rule I had you agree to this semester was no fermenting animals in the dorm!"

"Then I'm not breaking any rules," she said succinctly. "The hand is mummified and also humanoid. I'm simply rehydrating it."

"There are so many levels of ew in that statement that I don't even know where to begin. At least tell me you're keeping it on your side of the room."

"I won't tell you."

“W enesday!”

The slight smile on Wednesday’s face died after a quick second.

That had been something Enid noticed as of late. Their basic camaraderie aside, the last two loops were few and far between to find Wednesday in a good mood—not that her friend had much variance in moods, but there was a frustration she was starting to recognize more frequently with her .

Enid smiled back at the girl, but kept a wary eye on her. The fear of what that frustration could do to someone like her...

Wednesday leaned back in her chair, forcefully pushing the book on her desk away, and leveled Enid with a deadly stare from across the room. “Y our disregard for the scientific method is disgraceful.”

Affronted, Enid stood her ground. “I’m not gonna go around kissing our friends!”

“Y et I was deemed satisfactory?”

Enid was caught. She knew she was caught. Wednesday knew she was caught.

Their arguments as of late always seemed to skirt around the topic of their kiss, but never really breached the subject. Obviously , something about this loop was different.

Wednesday was a girl of action, so Enid thought if it was something worth her merit, then they’d eventually discuss it. The immediacy of the time loop situation obviously took precedence, but Enid would be lying if she said she wasn’t thinking about it almost every second of every passing day.

“Ahwell, I mean. I wasn’t.—

"Kiss Thing," Wednesday dared. The sound of furious tapping from across the room went ignored.

"Thing?"

"Yes. It'd caused the least amount of social suicide." The barest hint of a challenging smile on Wednesday's face made Enid's heart go into double time. "If that's what you're worried about."

"It's not the social suicide I'm worried about." In fact, it was the last thing on her mind. The casualness with which Wednesday could go a week without even bringing up the fact that they kissed and then just bluntly put it out there was something she should have prepared herself for in hindsight.

"Then what?"

"The *kissing* of it all," she exasperated.

Wednesday frowned. "I don't follow."

"Really?" She felt pained to explain. "I didn't kiss you on a whim or because I thought I had magical lips."

"Yes, you kissed me because you have romantic feelings for me. I'm aware."

Enid was lost for words. "Then why suggest kissing someone else?"

"If you're thinking I'd be jealous to see you kiss someone else, then I'd have to put into question our status as friends. Extreme circumstances and science outflank paltry emotions like jealousy."

Not following the logic, Enid asked, "So you'd be jealous if it *wasn't* for science?"

"Well, then we'd have to examine the circumstances. Are you even listening to me?"

"*God, we're not even dating,*" she mumbled.

"What was that?"

"I said *fine*, I'll kiss Thing. Only if he's okay with it." Enid couldn't move on from the topic quickly enough.

Once Thing agreed, Enid gingerly took his hand in hers and bent down to kiss his knuckles like a prince. He skittered up Wednesday's arm to tug at her braid and privately tell her something before leaving the room.

Enid clapped her hands together. "Okay, well, we won't really know if that did anything until the next loop." She actively avoided Wednesday's gaze. "Suggestion: if you're up for it, I think we should try and talk to other people outside of Nevermore. Not like I haven't tried, but I don't have that many connections in town. Plus," she added helpfully, "you're better at sussing out the weird in people."

Wednesday's face soured. "And what would outside help give us? Jericho, for all its supernaturality, isn't a hub for Outcast activity. Expanding our suspect pool would only cause us to lose focus."

"We have a suspect pool?" Enid shook her head. "Not the point. Listen, I don't wanna pull rank here, but I'm not gonna let you push me around on this either."

Wednesday mockingly gestured to the floor. "I think we would all love to hear your *piercing* insight."

Enid stood to her full height to face Wednesday. "I gave you a few loops to get your bearings, and instead, you immediately fell into research. Which—fine, whatever, that's your nature. I get it, but you don't know what I went through. You've had it easy *because* of me. So, forgive me if I'm trying to offer alternatives to save you from burning out. Don't act like it's the worst thing in the world to slow down. We're okay."

"In what realm of reality is this okay? Our research has gotten us nowhere. We have no leads. Anything we've attempted thus has been for naught." A broad mantle of pointed frustration crept over her posture. "I can't fathom how you've lasted so long without making any headway. Attempting to reach and then surpass the same strides every day—" she stopped and reigned in her heightened outburst with a heavy breath, her face the picture of disgruntled.

"So what if we're stuck here forever? Could be worse. No one's been murdered yet." Enid's attempt to ease the tension sounded less optimistic and more despondent, but something in the other girl's eyes shifted. It was clear another afternoon of futile research and failed experimentation weighed more heavily on Wednesday's shoulders than Enid had figured.

"Then by all means, you've been avoiding the subject enough for reasons I can't deduce, how did I react the other times you came to me? It might speed this along if I knew what I'd already tried."

All the bravado swept out of Enid, and she suddenly felt very small.

"I didn't," she admitted quietly.

"What do you mean?"

"I never came to you for help."

"At all?" Wednesday paused, her gaze distant for a moment before fiercely focusing back. "Enid, you've been trapped in these loops for *over a month* and *never* sought out my help?"

This felt different...

Enid was suddenly petrified, but Wednesday's demeanor gave away nothing.

Definitely an oversight on Enid's part, thinking that admitting this to Wednesday wouldn't then trigger a certain emotional response. But

that didn't account for why guilt was suddenly choking her or why she felt under scrutiny for something she didn't do wrong.

Enid flubbed her words. "No, I don't know? When you put it like that, it sounds bad, but I was so nervous about realizing I had a crush on you—it was confusing for a little bit." She shrugged. "As scary as the loops were, they also gave me the freedom to think. And I just couldn't bring myself to involve you. And with everything that happened last semester," she trailed off, not mentioning the stabbing or the imminent death of it all. "I don't know—it felt like this was just going to be another thing for you."

Wednesday remained silent.

Every day that Enid woke up in another loop, it felt like a tiny piece of her soul floated away. The repetition of it would drain anyone—continuing a life that didn't have any growth. It had the ability to tear at the deepest parts of you. It was a loss of will.

Involving Wednesday, despite how things turned out, seemed unfair at the time.

Enid scratched at her face absentmindedly. The angry red reminder of claw marks was barely visible now. "I know it's your nature, and you get sick pleasure out of it, but doom kind of follows you, Wednesday. If I could spare you from it for a little while, I would. I *did*."

The tension surrounding the two girls was a stage beyond uncomfortable. Every sound seemed amplified to the tenth degree. Every breath, every heartbeat, echoed off the walls and reverberated around them.

"I see..." Wednesday said after a minute.

"But you're here now, so it's okay. Right?" Enid blinked. "We're okay, right?"

"The loop' s ending soon. Let's finish up here," said W ednesday, her voice clipped.

A quick glance at her watch showed about four hours before another reset.

"W e still have some time to kill." Enid chuckled nervously . "Come on, let's do something. I'm sure we can think of something fun"…

Dark eyes pierced her searchingly, but it was almost as if Wednesday's gaze were looking right through Enid. Her brows furrowed as a decision was internally made.

"Y ou go on ahead, Enid. I think we're done here." There was a certain bite to her tone that conveyed more than just simple aggravation. "W e're no use to each other like this."

Her chest was heaving; cheeks were burning. Never before had Wednesday looked at her like that, looking straight for her weak points like her mother did. It was worse than anger , worse than pity. There was something in Wednesday that was ashamed to be in this predicament with her any longer.

All at once, like a defense mechanism, that explosive energy of her wolf pulsated from within. Smothering as much of the energy as she could, Enid was barely able to stop the ferocious glower in the other girl's direction.

Noting the subtle shift in Enid's bearing, Wednesday glowered right back. There was something more than anger in her eyes. It took Enid a beat to recognize the severity of it, but when she did, her stomach plummeted.

All the fight seemed to rush out of her.

"W ait W ednesday. Hold up, this feels wrong. We should talk—"

"*There's nothing to discuss*."

"No, if you just listen—"

Wednesday walked out of the room without a glance back.

Utterly confused at how quickly everything seemed to turn on its head, Enid could do nothing but wander alone until her alarm went off, ending the loop.

LOOP

The sun rose again at Nevermore Academy.

Blue eyes fluttered open gradually. Lithe limbs moved hesitantly.

The temptation to sleep the loop away was formidable, but Enid knew avoidance wouldn't solve anything. Nor would it dampen the rippling ache in her chest.

How the two of them left each other last night was obviously weighing heavily on her mind.

She called out. "Wednesday?"

"Yes, Enid?"

Already dressed and ready for the day, Wednesday was quietly putting her things together. The banal sight of the other girl hit Enid with an aggressively unpleasant bout of déjà vu.

There was no tension. There was no lingering feeling of animosity. Enid hesitated to say anything. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine." The reply came easily.

Dread forced its way into her body—a roughly shaped stone in the pit of her stomach.

"Are you sure? Because I feel like we should probably talk?"

Wednesday stilled, her back still to Enid. "T alk about what?"

She struggled to get the word out. "Y esterday."

Wednesday turned slightly, and any hope within Enid rotted away in an instant.

Her face remained neutral~~un~~settling. Devoid of something Enid couldnt place in the moment as the stone in her chest forced its way to her throat, brutishly scraping against her insides. The dread that hung above her head blossomed into a shroud that dropped upon her shoulders, completely enveloping her half of the room.

Wednesday's voice was clear. No trace of the hard biting tone remained. "f you are speaking on Eugene' s behalf, then id rather not have an uninterested third party berate me for my lack of participation at our Hummers meeting. f Eugene wants to complain, then he should confront me himself."

"Y ou know that's not what he's mad about."The response was automatic. t spilled from her lips as if some ghostly entity had wrenched its hand through her body and puppeted the words from her mouth. Because the real Enid was currently being dragged down into a depthless shadow by the heavy rock inside her body and the smothering cloak on her shoulders.

Please, no," she whispered when sense returned to her.

t was impossible to dream between loops, so she knew this wasnt a nightmare. No nightmare her mind could dredge up would be this cruel to her.

The rushing blood in her head pulsated against her skull as she took a shaky breath. "W ednesdaywhat do you remember?"

"About?"

"what we did yesterday?"

"Yesterday?" There's no hesitation. "We didn't do anything. After class, you went off with Yoko while I went into town with Eugene, then admittedly ditched him. You and Thing were gabbing over a magazine when I returned that evening."

She wasn't lying. That did happen yesterday. The yesterday that was over a month ago for Enid. The yesterday that felt like another lifetime to Enid. A yesterday that wouldn't've been that long ago for Wednesday, but proof enough that something happened where her and Enid's yesterdays didn't match up anymore.

"Nothing else?" There was no mask for her desperation.

"Not that I recall. Why?"

A hundred questions bubbled up in her chest and died on her tongue. "Don't worry about it. Uh, Thing," she called out. He appeared from under Wednesday's bed, pulling out a magazine. "Do *you* remember?"

'What?' he signed.

"Never mind."

"Did you need anything else?" Wednesday slung her bag over her shoulder. "I have work to do."

Enid shook her head, and Wednesday walked out the door. Maybe in this past month, she'd become too complacent, but Enid didn't go after her friend.

As the door closed, her hope didn't shatter but splintered. Enid was alone again.

The revelation crushed whatever bitter hope her heart held onto, and in its absence, a kind of panicked desperation replaced it, but in a way that panicked desperation was a welcome emotion.

She worked it out in her mind before the desperation could further grow.

- The amnesia was just temporary.

Or Wednesday's inclusion in the loop was the real temporary.

The loop, to Enid's great dismay, passed as normal. Wednesday returned on her way to an early lunch and barely spared a glance at Enid, who was currently bundled up in a cocoon of blankets.

Thing, sweet as he was, approached cautiously, getting as far as the unspoken divide between them before Wednesday called him back. "Let her rest."

'Are you okay? he signed to her.

Enid didn't respond, only stared at the empty space on the floor between them until the sound of Thing's languid skittering fed her guilt. She made a mental note to properly apologize to him later.

If *later* even mattered anymore.

Hefting the overly weighted blankets, Enid rolled over the second Wednesday made eye contact with her. She listened as the other girl's chunky boots moved about their room for a moment before hesitating near her bed. Enid squeezed her eyes shut and relaxed once the sound of the door opening and closing was long passed.

- She could kiss Wednesday again.

That seemed to be the trigger the first time, anchoring them together in the time loop.

It was an easy idea to consider, but she couldn't—she *wouldn't* do that to Wednesday again.

Despite the end result, there was a part of Enid that already felt bad about doing it in the first place. Her desperation was overwhelming

at that time, and it wasn't fair to take advantage of someone like that. When Wednesday woke up the next loop remembering what transpired, Enid was so shocked she didn't truly think of the consequences until later.

But Enid knew herself and desperation was a powerful motivator. Circumstances changed, and Enid was at the mercy of following them.

- She could accept this was always how it was going to end.

if this ever ended.

Enid felt at the end of her proverbial rope. Having to figure this out by herself again made her stomach turn.

She stayed contemplating until the loop ended.

Chapter End Notes

The original cut of this chapter had one more loop added at the end, but I thought naaah.

Please drop a comment and tell me your feelings, and thank you for reading!

Woe Is Like The Wind

Chapter Summary

Some moves are made. Some feelings are hurt. Some endings are revealed.

Chapter Notes

This chapter totally got away from me in editing and almost tripled in length...so that was fun. In hindsight, I probably should've broken it up into two chapters, but where's the fun in that? It's a rush to the end! Let's go!
All mistakes are my own.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

LOOP BEGINS

Enid Sinclair's Timeline of Time (subject to change)

- 7:30 AM LOOP BEGINS
- 8:08 AM Wednesday leaves dorm ~~(looks cute)~~
- 9:31 AM Yoko barges into dorm
- ~~9:45 AM Go to talk to Wednesday~~
- 10:38 AM Eugene confronts Wednesday
- 10:42 AM Greenhouse unattended (no weed)
- 10:53 AM Bianca fencing mishap
- 11:20 AM AVOD ADMIN BUILDING
- 12:14 PM Stoner incident boys dorm (9 upperclassmen petrified)
- 12:14 PM Wednesday calls (DO NOT hang up until dentist appointment mention)
- 1:3? PM Quad overtaken by botany club
- 1:15 PM Breach of access?
- 1:43 PM Ajax locks self out of dorm (wanders quad until after dinner)

- ~~1:50 PM Go talk to W ednesday~~
- 2:02 PM Librarian distracted (doesnt allow book checkout during holiday? dumb)
- 3:46 PM Eugene trips and knocks over a hive (Thing s fault?)
- 3:59 PM Thing steals Hummer honey (blackmail?)
- ~~4:00 PM Go talk to W ednesday~~
- 4:30-5:00 PM W ednesday's torture device backfires (in bad mood ~~but still cute~~)
- 4:39 PM W eird smell in Infirmary (not worth investigation)
- 5:24 PM Music hall empty (good nap spot)
- 6:30 PM DO NOT EA T SOUP
- 7:12 PM Nightshades meeting (booooring)
- 8:48 PM Quad empty
- 9:57 PM W ednesday returns to dorm ~~(doesnt want to talk but cute)~~
- ~~10:00 PM Go talk to W ednesday~~
- 11:45 PM LOOP ENDS

It was the first loop where Enid cried.

Waking up, she was affected by a now overly familiar sequence. First came the choir of bird song from out the window, then the reflection of sunlight that bounced off a mirror momentarily blinding her, all tied together with the faint citrusy fragrance of Thing's daily hand cream that hit her nose.

Seven loops later, and the monotonous act of it all just broke something within her. It wasnt by the causality of hopelessness but a revelation that inaction wouldnt magically fix whatever force it was that trapped her in a time loop.

It was the first time Enid had realized how demonstrative she'd been acting; a lost week that felt like a wasted indulgence, only made more poignant by the fact that a feeling of complete isolation was possible even when surrounded by dozens of people.

A prime example was when, from across the room, W ednesday glanced at her as she was heading out and said, "I will be

unavailable for the majority of the day. If anyone, mainly Eugene, comes looking for me later, please direct them away from the lake until tomorrow. That is, unless they want to risk the threat of my retribution."

Enid gave a half-hearted grunt of acknowledgement, not really listening. She'd heard the other girl say that exact spiel numerous times already and didn't feel like responding with her usual, *"No problem, roomie!*, because the point was suddenly lost to her. *Later* may never come for Enid. She was stuck with the promise of *laters* and *tomorrows* with no indication of when they would happen.

The sudden disillusionment with reality was so visceral that Enid almost wondered if she had imagined it all.

Almost out the door, Wednesday was stopped as Thing skittered up her shoulder and started to sign furiously. After an intensely hushed back and forth, she looked over her shoulder with mild concern and asked, "Is there something bothering you?"

"You don't have to act like you care," Enid replied, still in the throes of her regretful epiphany.

Maybe it was the lack of bite in her tone or the almost casual way she threw the retort back, but Wednesday did not bat an eye. Not that Enid expected her to, but it did reinforce the point that it may never matter how Enid reacted ever again. She was always going to have the opportunity to do it all over again.

And again.

And again.

Wednesday stared at her for an uncomfortable moment before walking over and gingerly sitting on the edge of Enid's bed. Then, after another uncomfortable second of deliberate struggle, placed a consolatory hand on her knee.

"What are you doing?" Enid had to ask, mildly concerned by the other girl's behavior. There was the slightest show of internal contention that she could see—a twitch in her eyebrow, the subtle clench of her jaw—as the girl contemplated her next words. Or maybe judging if she should say them at all.

"My mother used to do this when I was much younger and only just understanding my true nature. I used to loathe the blatant show of *affection*," she fought the word, "but have come to recognize its practicality as it's also something you obviously covet. Don't think too much of it," she added with the slightest tinge of embarrassment.

Wednesday was on her bed for all of seventy-two seconds, but something permanently shifted in Enid—something akin to a specific emotion she didn't have the heart to entertain just now. It was as precious as it was irresistible. And it had unfurled fully. Like forgotten coals given enough of a spark to ignite a flame back to life. To take her eyes off Wednesday at that moment would have felt like a betrayal to those unmitigated feelings, so she watched with bated breath until the other girl retreated back and reached for the door.

"Wednesday?"

"Hm?"

Enid bit the inside of her cheek, careful not to expose the ignition of flame she felt inside. "Do you ever think we…"

"What?"

She expelled a breath, mournful of her confidence. "Have you ever had really intense déjà vu?"

Wednesday thought about it. "Visions can sometimes feel that way."

"Have you had any recently?"

She shook her head. “Seems as if nothing of merit has happened at school as of late to warrant them.”

Enid laughed bitterly. “Just means we’re due for something to happen, I guess.” Wednesday didn’t say anything, so she quickly pivoted. “Anyway, thanks. I know that was a lot for you. And don’t worry, I’ll try to make sure no one bothers you today.”

The other girl looked at her strangely for a second, then continued her way out of the room. The sound of the door closing reverberated in the silence. It sharpened the vanity of Enid’s new reality.

She wouldn’t do anything. Not now. Not when the uncertainty of her predicament was so in flux. But she went through the motions. Because it was too early for her to lie down defeated. Because even if she looked back on this void of a week, there was the smallest spark giving life to some foreign flame set in the center. Because Enid Sinclair didn’t give up after a few days of disappointment. She had lived with her mother her entire life, and disappointments weren’t anything new.

And maybe one day she could talk to Wednesday about these things she didn’t want to think about; but for now, all she had was this one week—seven loops, and who knows how many more to come.

So she cried. Because it was all she had.

LOOP 6

From outside, Enid could hear a melodic birdsong being sung under a ray of brilliant sunlight that pleasantly warmed the skin, and she immediately sank deeper into her bed to block it out. The thick blanket she slept with was a convenient safeguard from the rest of the world and her only immediate line of defense against its perils. Completely wrapped in the soft artificial cocoon, Enid would’ve happily stayed there for the next fifteen hours or until time stopped passing altogether.

Wednesday's clunky footfalls were, unfortunately, the only indication that time was indeed passing. Digging a small hole through the fabric, Enid peeked her eyes out to watch the other girl amble about.

"I will be unavailable for the majority of the day," Wednesday said, her back turned. "If anyone comes looking for me, please direct them away from the lake."

"Sure." Enid's voice was muffled beneath her blankets, eyes still set on her roommate.

The other girl paused, took two steps towards the door, sighed with clear annoyance, then glared over in her direction. "You need to get out of bed." Her tone was direct—commanding.

Affronted, she glared back. "No, I'm fine."

"*Enid*."

Ignoring the way her name said with such explicit frustration sent a thrill through her spine, Enid instead lazily replied, "What?"

"You can't stay in bed all day again."

"Says *you*. This bed is my *repentance*," she argued, which only received an aggressive eye roll from her roommate. She pulled the blanket tighter around her body. "It's a long weekend. I can do what I want."

"Then what was all that fluff about starting each day with your *best paw forward* this semester? Commitments are—" The muscles in Wednesday's jaw flexed. She scowled and shook her head as she left. "You're not setting a very compelling example."

"*You're* not a very compelling example," she mocked as her roommate walked out. The door closed with a heavy thud. "Let's see how *you* handle an infinite looping time prison where you're its only—"

Enid sat up suddenly with a sharp inhale. The movement gave her a quick bout of vertigo. Raised bumps erupted across her skin, now exposed to the drafty room as the blanket pooled around her waist. Her head buzzed.

"*Again*," she whispered.

Unsteady was her breath as her roommate's words caught up to her. Her brain raced to make sense of it—to disregard the slip as inconsequential, like she had with so many things in the last couple of days. But instinct was a difficult thing to ignore when it beat like a distress call against her skull.

Her head was a mess of calculations and reckonings as Enid tripped over her legs, trying to get to the door and then swiftly through the hallway in an attempt to catch up with Wednesday. She got as far as the top of the stairs before realizing the other girl was long gone.

Rushing back to the room, Enid ripped open her notebook and started furiously writing. Each word fueled the irate wolf that hadn't quelled since Wednesday broke out of the loops.

Enid Sinclair's Won't Go Down Without A Fight But Is Still Really Sad About Everything List Of Anomalies (Version 1.3)

- Thing
  - Doesn't follow Wednesday to the lake
  - Deviates from schedule
  - Shows up around campus
- Yoko
  - Deviates from schedule
  - Checking in during the evening (on behalf of Wednesday?)
- Wednesday
  - Speech not lining up? (bad memory?)
  - longing glances? count: 1 (seeing what I want?)

“…again…”

The word *again* echoed in her mind in conjunction with her running heartbeat. “What did I do yesterday?” Memories too deep in the fog of routine struggled to reveal themselves. It was a gamble trying to think back to the yesterday before the loops started.

It had seemingly been so long she could call it a lifetime ago.

It was Thursday. Classes were canceled halfway through after some upperclassmen botched their biology lesson and genetically modified some deadly plant in the conservatory to grow at a rate that was *unquantifiably hazardous to the student body until such a time the threat could be mollified*.

Enid had nothing else to do except go back to the dorm after a stressful call with her mother, and decided to sulk in her bed until she felt better. Wednesday had left with Eugene and didn't return until almost curfew. Or maybe after curfew? Enid was already asleep by that point, so from Wednesday's perspective, she would have been in bed all day because *tomorrow* never happened.

“Or kept happening for me at least.”…

But why did Wednesday deviate from her routine and confront her about it? If there was anything these loops taught her, it was that the routine was strict. No one deviated from their schedules without some outside influence.

Surely she stayed in bed in some previous loop and hadn't triggered a reprimand from Wednesday, but even Enid could admit it was hard to remember the beginning loops when she was on her own.

“*...can't stay in bed all day again…*”

She went over the last three loops in her head half a dozen times. There were clear discrepancies, but also clear explanations for every deviation. The three loops since Wednesday's disconnect weren't

enough of a statistical grouping to convince her that something was truly amiss, but Enid also trusted her gut.

Something was wrong, and Enid knew thinking too hard about it would not be good in the end for her if revealed to be true.

After skirting the edge of uncomfortable truths, she eventually convinced herself that the reason Wednesday reacted differently from other times was because Enid was sure she was emanating major depressive vibes from her side of the dorm. She staggered back to her bed, slid down the side of it, and hugged her knees to her chest, burying her head in them. The unsatisfied beating of her heart slowed a bit with the self-made disappointment, but even that was short-lived as someone knocked on her door.

Wicked smile. Pin-straight hair. Signature sunglasses.

"Yoko," Enid said through a strained smile, "you're early"…

Yoko's smile dropped in confusion. "Huh?"

"I mean, what an unexpected surprise."

"Is it?" She looked behind Enid incredulously as if searching for something.

"You tell me. What are you doing here?"

"You're not gonna let me in first?"

Enid suppressed an exasperated groan. "Not to be totally rude, you know I love you, but I'm about to have a full-blown meltdown, and I kind of wanted to do that in peace."

"Wow," she whistled, "Wednesday wasn't wrong."

Yoko's appearance did nothing but fuel her suspicion, and knowing Wednesday was involved, that suspicion was getting harder to ignore. Enid's shoulders tensed.

"Okay , bye." In no mood for niceties, she went to close the door , but Yoko jammed her foot in the way . For a horrifying split second, Enid contemplated how much strength she would need to use against her vampiric friend to push her out of the way.

"What the hell?" Yoko added a bit more force to her foot. "Uh, no. *Open the door* . You owe me. Or have you forgotten that Divina and I have been working overtime keeping Ajax preoccupied?"

She did forget. But only because the favor was moot when it served no purpose in eternity.

Grudgingly, Enid inched the door wider to allow her friend in.

With a graceful waltz, Yoko perched on the corner of Enid's bed, patting the space beside her. "What is it that's got you so stressed that Mr. Doom and Gloom all but strong-armed me to check on you? Come on, tell Auntie Yoko all your troubles."

Enid stood by the door, back to her friend, deciding if she shouldn't just run out to the lake and get this over with.

"Enid?"

With heavy steps, she walked over to her friend, collapsed on the floor, and lay her head on Yoko's lap. "I'm stuck in a time loop, I'm in love with my roommate, and I think she's lying to me."

"Oh..."

The heels of her palms dug into her eyes. She refused to cry about this anymore. It was futile to think that everything she did had no meaning. That her life at this point was forfeit to the strange machinations of whatever had her trapped that she couldn't escape.

"You know," Yoko piped up, her hand gently petting Enid's hair, "I have a cousin on my dad's side who was stuck in a time loop. Don't

know how it happened, but he brings it up every holiday. Ican call him up later if you want?"

Enid smiled sadly. Her tolerance was quickly draining. "That'd be great, Yoko. Thanks..."

"W ednesday, huh?" Y oko pursed her lips together. "I mean, Iget it. She kinda gets under your skin in like a freaky hot way if you're into that. Ithink it has to be the way she stares at you. Like she knows exactly how to push your buttons."

Suddenly agitated, Enid pushed off the floor and paced the room. "M ore than that. She forces her way into your life even when she' s being as standoffish as possible." The words just wouldn't stop. "She has so much charm and personality despite claiming she doesn't have an emotional bone in her body. She's fearless and loyal to a fault sometimes, but it's only because she cares about others more than she realizes. M ore than I used to give her credit for . She's"…

"She' s pretty hot."

Enid blushed in spite of herself. "She doesn't lie to you," she admitted quietly .

Yoko choked on a laugh. "Y ou sure we're talking about the same Wednesday Addams?"

Enid rolled her eyes. "I know what she is. I know that she lies about shit all the time. M ostly to get out of stuf f she doesn't care for. but not *this*," she said more to herself. "Not—I just thought we were past it all at this point. God, she's so *frustrating."*

"S this a need-to-crash-at-my-room situation?"

"I wouldn't do anything for me."

"T ime loop, right. Sorry." She looked Enid in the eye. "So. she' s lying to you?"

"I think so."

"You *think* or you're sure?"

Enid didn't answer.

Yoko's expression turned somber. "What are you gonna do?"

There was a lot she *could* do. Nothing that seemed pertinent or worth her time at the moment, not that time was a finite resource. "I don't know"…

"Let me try again. What do you *want* to do?"

That was an easier answer. "I need to talk to her."If she could bring herself to do it, was another question.

"Great! We have a solution. I love a solution!"

"That's *not* a solution,"she said despondently, already aware that this would not be an easy talk. Especially if her suspicions were right. "A *solution* would be ending the time loop so I don't have to face Wednesday at all. Who knows if talking to her won't spiral and make everything worse."

"Worse than how you feel right now?"

"I can think of so many more worse things than how I feel right now."

"Perfect! Then go talk to Wednesday."She chuckled when Enid froze. "You should loosen up. You look really tense."

"I'll ask Thing for a neck massage later,"she grumbled.

"All right,"she patted Enid's shoulder and got up. "I'm off. I love you, but I also know when to leave a spiral alone. Catch me for dinner."

"I won't."

"You will!"

"Whatever. Don't eat the soup."

The short distraction was a brief relief, but it didn't last. Yoko had shut the door on an empty room because, as far as Enid was concerned, she ceased to exist in reality at least thirty days ago.

Now there was the matter of next steps.

Enid had never confronted a broken heart before.

She had never gotten far enough to have her heart broken. Wednesday could be unintentionally cruel, but it was different when it came to how she treated Enid. Or at least she'd like to think so. To befriend Wednesday had been a trial in and of itself, and more than anything, she wished that that actually meant something.

What did it mean for Enid—after confessing to and kissing her roommate, that there was a part of her that remained convinced that Wednesday had decided to distance herself in an effort to not expressly hurt Enid's feelings. If Wednesday was lying to her for such a misguided reason, then how was she supposed to react to that? How was she supposed to feel about it?

Doubt filtered through her mind. Maybe this was just the natural occurrence of things. Maybe Enid was second-guessing herself for no reason. Maybe the loops weren't eternal, and after so much time had passed, little deviations would start to occur—enough to give Enid hope, just to crush it all over again. Maybe Wednesday was her torture in this.

In the end, there were too many variables to consider, and Enid was getting a thudding headache juggling it all. She walked to the balcony to clear her mind.

All of Nevermore was smeared with sunlit fog, a ghostly schoolscape sinking into the morning mist. The other dorm buildings surfaced

along her eyeline through the fog like the bones of a skeleton’s ribs. Behind them stood the clock tower , which glowed with soft, yellow luminescence. And beyond that was an expanse of autumn colored trees and a wider unknown.

As calming as the landscape was, it only reminded her of what she'd lost and continued to miss out on.

She felt small and lonely, but it wasn't because of sadness. Enid had always been alone in some capacity. Feeling lonely was different from just being alone. Just like feeling hopeless and being tired of feeling hopeless were two distinctive kinds of feelings.

Enid was tired of feeling hopeless. The only way she'd get answers was by confronting that feeling.

So she climbed onto the roof, found a way down, and ran off into the woods, avoiding everyone and everything.

Time truly disappeared then. Trees, leaves, dirt, and the canopy of shade above her. That was all she could sense. It was natural. Primal. Every pump of her legs brought her wolf closer to the surface. And until the moment the loop ended, Enid felt free.

LOOP

Enid awoke with the end of a scream on her lips and her body in a cold sweat.

Something in her chest beat with the rhythm of an insatiable grief. Every afflicted pulse seemed to exist in the space between extreme insensibility and dogged sentience. For some moments, she was awake and filled with a slow-consuming vexation, the kind that never relented and crumbled everything from the inside. For all the other moments, it was as though she had gone somewhere else.

comes looking for me later, please direct them away from the lake until tomorrow."

Enid couldn't remember replying or anything that really happened in the moments after. What seemed to be a few minutes had gone by before she realized she'd just been sitting in bed disassociating. A new experience, but not an unexpected one.

"Get it together, Enid," she chastised herself.

She took out her phone almost on instinct. Texting had little use to her nowadays, but Enid knew the catharsis of sending a message knowing the other person would never receive it. So she sent one to Wednesday.

'Im not giving up.'

She waited for the familiar ringtone to alert, but it was silent in their room. Alarm bells rang in her head instead. She tried another message.

Silence.

She could feel the heat drain from her face, and without a second more wasted, she was already backing out of the room and out the door.

It was such an arbitrary thing—almost silly, to think a teenager with their phone was something that could provoke someone into such a panicked state; but the one hard truth about these loops that Enid could confidently say was always certain, was that people didn't change. Change happened because of growth, whether by outside influences or internal justifications that had the proper amount of time to gestate.

Those things didn't exist in a time loop where everything reset automatically.

So, within a time loop, there were things that were unconsciously ingrained in the routine. Things that were seemingly impossible to influence because of how personal they were to everybody. Enid would describe them as akin to an individual's nature.

She knew to avoid the quad around the afternoon because Ajax liked being around the increased flow of students. She knew the upstairs balconies would always find either Bianca or Xavier during the day because they liked the dominance and isolation over everyone else, respectively. She knew Eugene would always confront Wednesday on the way to breakfast, or later if intervened, unless Enid placated him beforehand because he was so intrinsically passionate about his friendship with her and his dedication to the club. She knew Yoko would be mad at Kent all day for putting garlic in her breakfast smoothie yesterday and would need at least a week before she got over it. And without a shadow of a doubt, Enid knew Wednesday never had her phone.

These were all basic truths, and no one deviated from them.

Unless they were, like Enid, living each loop like a new day and allowing change to influence their behaviors.

The lake was eerie at this time of day. Clouds of early morning fog still clung around the middle and edges of the water, giving the lake a melancholy feel to it. Wednesday stood near the shore, in typical fashion, putting together parts of Pugsley's gifted torture device.

"Wednesday," Enid said with difficulty as she approached the other girl cautiously. It was a strange sensation to both experience extreme relief and hurt. Already, the pinprick of tears formed in the corner of her eyes as a tightness in her throat grasped steadily.

"Yes, Enid?"

"Can you look at me, please?" She could hear how broken her voice sounded and hoped Wednesday couldn't, but if she couldn't, then

what did that say about Wednesday and what Enid meant to her?

t took a second longer than Enid felt it should have, but her roommate did eventually lock eyes with her. Wednesday's face was a painted study of innocence and perfect unconcern. A sudden frozen grip in Enid' s chest squeezed the uncertainty out of her , making it easier to breathe as she stared at her roommate, who looked back with dark, empty eyes.

t was really the only proof she needed.

f there was anything she knew about W ednesday, it was how she looked at people. She had mastered the kind of vacuous, dead stare towards others in an attempt to mask her own pathos, but Enid had seen the other girl in varying emotional states. Granted, they were subtle, but they existed, and Enid could dif ferentiate between them.

The last few loops, she hadn't really looked in W ednesday's direction because looking at her meant pain, when all it would've reinforced was the fact that they weren't connected anymore. But there was no veil between them now. Nothing to hide behind. Nothing but Wednesday's eyes and the complete recognition they held for her.

And that was all Enid needed.

But she knew denial was easy . She knew Wednesday's tricks and had fallen prey to many of them over the course of their friendship. She'd have to push her to confess.

The tears were easy to expel. t wasn't like despair was a foreign emotion to conjure up— or an overwhelming one.

"I don't know what else to do." Errant tears fell down Enid' s cheeks. Her voice was a hoarse whisper. "I can't keep pretending every day isn't tearing me up inside."

Wednesday's chest started heaving slightly.

Hook.

"Do you know what it is to wake up alone?" She took a step into Wednesday's personal space. "I know it doesn't make much sense to you but I don't want to go through this alone anymore." She swore the other girl didn't take her eyes off Enid's lips as she moved closer again.

Line.

"I'm sorry , Wednesday. I hope you won't be mad at me."

The second before their lips met, Enid felt a gentle push against her clavicle and the chill of Wednesday's hand like a brand on her skin.

"It won't work again," Wednesday said quietly . She pulled back and tilted her head away. The gravel under her heels sank deep into the shoreline. A deafening silence fell between the two girls.

Enid sucked in a sharp breath. With a clawing at her stomach, all the turmoil Wednesday had unleashed at her a couple of days ago surfaced. Her mouth, her eyes, her very bones seemed to pull tighter.

"Wednesday," said Enid, in the calmest voice she could muster , even as her pulse raced, "tell me you didn't." She didn't wait for an answer. "*You lied.*" The words come out breathy and slow . They were mixed with the cool bite of relief and sharp pang of anger , and confusion.

Tears blurred her vision as a spark of something jolted inside of her primal and shifting. It burned red hot. Built of rage and embarrassment bubbling just underneath the surface. Waiting to rip out of her own skin.

"*Enid*." Wednesday's tone was concerned, cautious. Her eyes no longer vacant.

She angrily wiped at the tears on her face. "Why did you lie?" she bit out.

Wednesday took note of her changes and contemplated her words. "It seemed like my presence wasn't making the investigation go any smoother."

"What, so you decided it'd be better off alone?" Her eyes flashed for the first time in a long time. Claws extended and began to slowly morph.

It felt good.

"I was a distraction to you, and I thought it'd work more efficiently—"

"Without me?" There was a growling undertone to her voice now.

Wednesday didn't answer, which only angered Enid more. Her teeth sharpened. Canines poked through her lips. Pupils dilated.

All at once, she thought back to the weeks' worth of loneliness she endured in the beginning and the agony she carried with her constantly. Then the crushing dismay when she found out she was alone again. Wednesday had no idea how truly off-kilter she'd been feeling and how much impulsivity she'd been holding at bay.

"I *needed* you," she growled, then slashed at Wednesday's machine as she stalked backward. Sparks of metal littered the air like glittering confetti. "You were the only thing keeping me sane."

"Enid," Wednesday said evenly.

She heard the warning tone, but it was drowned out by the blood rushing in her ears. Her skin was on fire. Her breathing slowed as she took heaving, intimidating breaths. Again, she felt something in her chest, something trembling, something squirming. It was inside her, something alive, something trying to move.

At first, she was horrified. But though she could not really think—how could she think, as she was lost in the sensations—she started to understand. The thing moving in her chest was her own heart. It was beginning to beat first rapidly, anxiously, a mirror of her agitation. Then its beats grew stronger, more assured—primal. The same cadence she experienced on the night of the blood moon.

Her lungs begged for air, so Enid Sinclair breathed deep and howled.

"*Enid!*" Wednesday grabbed the sides of Enid's face and forced her down, eyes wide, boring into Enid's frenzied stare. "*Enough!*" Her voice projected with far more force behind it than either girl had heard before.

The transformation was momentarily arrested, but Enid's body remained utterly tense.

"Calm," Wednesday said like a mantra. She pressed a hand to Enid's jaw, gently working the tight muscles loose. Then Wednesday's hands were clenched in the seams of Enid's blouse, and she dragged her forward.

There was a moment, *a single moment*, when Enid was looking into Wednesday's eyes, and Wednesday was looking into hers, and finally—*finally,* the barest calm reached through.

Enid pushed away everything after that and simply moved. As cautiously as the first time they kissed, Wednesday leaned her head up and pressed their lips together again.

Wednesday's mouth was on hers, punishingly sweet, then a bruising warmth made everything vicious and hungry rise up in Enid with a swiftness that devastated her.

To stop a werewolf's transformation was no easy feat. It either came from unguaranteed years of practice, which Enid's months-ago-rebirth held none. Or with a shock or stimulation so great that it negated the overpowering cycle of said transformation.

Wednesday Addams was that shock.

"Calm," she mumbled against her lips.

With blood still pounding in her ears, the sharp features of Enid's face that had begun to grow receded back to their natural angles. She pushed Wednesday's hands off once she felt sufficiently back in control, but she couldn't stop the embarrassing sting of tears rolling down her cheeks. Or the powerful ache in her chest that wanted her to step back into the other girl's space again and again until she had her fill.

"I'm *fine*." It was more forceful than she intended, but courtesy wasn't high on her list of etiquette at the moment. Wednesday stared at her indefensibly, seemingly not at all bothered that she was almost the victim of a wolf out. In fact, Enid took special note of the fading, wide-eyed, almost excited demeanor of the other girl. "*This is insane*," she breathed out.

"Sanity is a construct made by those who wish to control what normalcy means so they can profit off it," Wednesday said plainly.

Enid huffed with exasperation. "How can you be so"…

"What?"

"Do you even see the issue here? I almost wolfed out in the middle of campus, and you're acting so calm like you haven't been lying to me for days." She gestured around wildly, unable to remain still. "I can't even tell if I'm angry at you because I'm so relieved that you *did* lie."

"I made a calculated decision," Wednesday explained. Though she didn't even seem convinced of her words. "Everything would have been fine once I figured this all out."

"Fine? You call *this* fine?" She scoffed. "You know, sometimes the mystery isn't more important than the people you care about. I

thought after last year you understood that." Wednesday had the decency to look conflicted, but it wasn't enough to soothe Enid's bruised ego. "Having people around to help isn't a bad thing, and I'm sick of trying to convince you of that."

Wednesday's frown deepened. "I remember you saying you learned a lot from me despite my shortcomings."

"*Criminal* things, which don't count in this situation." Embarrassment flared again in her chest and spread to her cheeks. "*And you still can't admit when you're in the wrong!*" She laughed mirthlessly at the clear example of the other girl's stubbornness.

They stared down each other for a tense moment. Neither girl relented.

At some point, the words just ran out, and Enid walked away, not trusting herself not to lash out again.

She wandered. All around campus. Through every open door she could find. Everywhere, nowhere. She was too restless, but not enough to run in the woods again. Because even in her anger, she didn't want to be far from Wednesday—the Wednesday that had never left her.

She contemplated next steps, gripped with the realization that she had never been alone, replayed that kiss in her head despite the anger, and let the tenuous betrayal of her best friend ebb through her veins even if her heart didn't want to listen.

The loop ended without her seeing Wednesday again.

LOST

Maybe a borderline wolf out was all Enid needed because she felt the most clearheaded she had in weeks. Was she still mad that it took ten whole minutes for Wednesday to look in her direction this

morning? Yes, but that didn't mean she was ready to hash things out.

Though their friendship was barely a year old, Enid knew that any conflict resolution with her roommate was settled better once Wednesday was left alone to stew in her wrongdoing. A kind of clarifying empathy developed in the solitude.

If nothing else, Enid was going to get that clarifying empathy.

Leaving Wednesday to it, Enid had a moment's hesitation as she reached for the door to leave. The feeling of Wednesday's eyes on her back compelled her to turn around. "I'll be in Yoko's room. Don't come after me. Don't send Thing to spy on me. Just leave me alone."

She didn't have to look to know Wednesday nodded her agreement. She shut the door softly behind her.

LOSS

Enid woke up as quickly as she ever had; dressed, ready, and out the door in fifteen minutes flat, leaving Wednesday without so much as a second glance.

Her hurried steps stopped short of the quad, not having thought through what it was she wanted to do except put some space between them—which in and of itself felt impossible. Wednesday permeated every inch of Nevermore Academy. The girl had left her mark on this school as much as she had on Enid's heart. Both the valuable and mundane memories of her and the gothic-esque girl were around, no matter where her feet led.

It was hard to pinpoint exactly what about this whole ordeal that made Enid so upset; Wednesday lying, the fact that the loops hadn't changed, the time wasted.

With a now clear head, she understood Wednesday's outlook to a point. The lying itself, even she could justify. The enigmatic girl remained true to herself, and while it came at the cost of Enid's sanity, she couldn't very well fault her for sticking to it. It was more the fact that Enid had partly convinced herself that her confession was going to fundamentally change their dynamic and could have maybe prevented this kind of thing from happening.

How silly of her…

At the end of it all, they were teenagers. They made mistakes and fucked with each other. Deep down, Enid understood that, but it still hurt all the same. She was allowed to be hurt.

Without a mind and a vested interest in avoiding her roommate, Enid eventually found her way towards the outskirts of the southern perimeter and took the winding beaten path leading to the Lupen cages. A place she now had the privilege to familiarize herself with more. The incident at the lake notwithstanding.

"Hey, Enid." A lackadaisical voice broke her inner tormenting thoughts. An upperclassman werewolf, whose name escaped Enid at the moment, lay comfortably in the corner of one of the cages.

She politely waved at him. "Wolf out?" she asked, gesturing the obvious.

"I think it's just indigestion, but can't be too careful, ya know?" He shrugged like it didn't matter either way.

"Gotta watch out for that soup," she agreed.

"Soup?"

"Yeah, I heard someone messed with—nevermind. It's not important."

He smiled warmly, even at her apparent awkwardness. "You doin' all right? Eatin' your vitamins and stayin' energized?

"Yep!" Her voice rose like she was answering questions for her doctor. "Three square meals a day."

"Good. Good. It's important to keep your strength. Not meanin' to scare ya, but the first year after you turn is by far the worst. I can't tell ya the number o' times I woke up covered in blood thinkin' I killed my entire dorm hall. But nope, just chickens." He laughed heartily.

Enid struggled to match his cheer. "Trust me, I know. I saw it all with my brothers. If one of them didn't show up at breakfast, we assumed we'd see him in a few hours, give or take."

"Yeah," his smile fell, "those fellas freak me out. No offense. One fell off the roof last week and got up like it was nothin'. Never seen anythin' like it."

Enid cringed. "Fortunately, they're pretty durable. I don't think I've ever known them not to throw each other off tall buildings. I thought it was a werewolf trait until I came here."

He shook his head as if he knew what that was like. "Well, look out for 'em if you can. Helps to have one clear head around in a pack. We're not indestructible."

Enid tucked the hair behind her left ear, subconsciously brushing against three faint lines of scarring. "I don't know it," she said softly.

"You sure you're all right?"

Enid bit the inside of her lip. There wasn't any harm in getting advice from someone she didn't really know. He would forget in ten hours that this ever happened anyway.

"I almost wolfed out yesterday," she started. "I mean, I *did* pretty much." He nodded seriously. Listening intently. Enid's shoulders relaxed a little. "W— *my friends* they lied to me and kind of abandoned me when I needed them. It all came out after confronting them, and I couldn't stop myself. It was like I had no control over my

body, but was also fully in control. Does that make sense? I don't know it was like my body was on fire and frozen stiff at the same time. I'd never felt so—"

"Groovy?"

Enid looked at him strangely. "Sure"…

"Well, I don't have to remind ya that strong emotions can trigger a wolf out no matter what time of day it is. Seems like you got to the knife's edge. But you said *almost*? What snapped you out of it? If ya don't mind me askin'."

"They did—my friend—who I was upset with."

He whistled. "Seems like a special friend."

"She is." Enid looked down and frowned glumly.

"I don't know your life, Enid, but that sounds like someone I would keep close to my side as long as I could." He sat up and sincerely leveled with her. "Listen, we're young, we're all developin' our abilities and tryna navigate life at a damn boarding school for Outcasts. Shit's gonna happen. Fights between friends are gonna happen. You gotta be the one to choose if ya wanna make those connections last or not. Otherwise, you've set yourself out to be a lone wolf for the rest of your life, and you know as well as I do, that's not in our nature."

He was right. Hearing the same advice she had already been thinking only solidified it. Even now, she could feel that the anger had mostly faded. She just wanted to see Wednesday.

"I gotta go. Thank you!" Enid never remembered his name. She felt kinda bad. "See you around!"

"Stay groovy, Enid!"

They seemed to be of the same mind because the moment Enid stepped out from the Lupen cages, Wednesday was there, seated on a bench outside the gates, clearly waiting for her.

"We need to talk." Enid was proud of how smooth she sounded, as if she hadn't been about to race off to find the other girl.

Wednesday looked at her with slight trepidation and whatever passed for shame in the Wednesday Addams book of emotions. "Okay."

Enid let the bait drop.

"I assume you followed me here because we're *so totally* in sync with each other and you just couldn't go another minute without seeing me?" She made a point of taking a seat far enough away from the other girl to simulate the divide still between them, but close enough to touch if necessary. "Jokes aside, I'm mad at you, if you couldn't tell. Like *really* mad. That was super messed up what you did."

Wednesday spoke slowly, as if still forming the words together in her mind. "If it felt to you that I was regressing back on old habits, then I won't refute that. I'll even admit that you were correct."

"And it wasn't even that you—no—held on." She stared at her in shock. "Was that an apology? Like an actual *apology* from *Wednesday Addams*: notorious stubborn wannabe detective? Because I'm not sure if I heard a *sorry* in there. Surely someone as smart as her would know how to put together a bare minimum apology."

Was she laying it thick? Yes, but this was a rare moment for Enid, and she was going to milk it for all its worth.

The muscles in Wednesday's jaw flexed noticeably as her eye twitched, trying in vain to suppress a monstrous glare. "I'm *sorry*… that seeing your sad, pitiable face every loop we restarted was becoming intolerable on my psyche."

Enid shrieked in offense. "Oh my god! That is so uncalled—"

"*Im sorry* Im sorry , Enid," she said tiredly , then crossed her arms and turned away. "A week had passed, and Id made no progress. It was unlike me and seeing how helpful you were trying to be wasnt aiding. So Iput it upon myself to figure out this infernal manipulation of time we were stuck in so as to not burden you and hopefully get to an answer quicker ." She paused. "facted irrationally ."

"By lying," Enid clarified. Her laugh was a short and bitter bark. "You could've just told me that seeing me upset made you frustrated. That's what friends in time loops do. They tell each other their feelings and emotions so the other person knows to look out for them."

Wednesday let out a woeful breath. "Everything was much easier to construe when Iwas only trying to prevent a mass murdering pilgrim from coming back to life. Oh, to be young." She slumped back against the bench, doing everything in her power not to look toward Enid.

Enid smiled wistfully. She could see how earnest the other girl was trying to be. "I can bet having endless time to think about yourself was torture in its own right for you so Iwont drag this out anymore. Dont do things on your own," she warned. "I dont care if you think it's better. It' s not."

"I only did what Ithought was best...for the people Icare about."

"Earnestness is always better shared." She of fered her hand to Wednesday, who took it after a slight moment's hesitation. Welcoming the brief chill that shot up her arm, she squeezed the other girl's hand tightly. A cool balm. "If Icame on too strong, then that's totally on me, and Im sorry , but Ionly wanted to do this with you. It meant Iwasnt alone anymore. It meant if anything happened, then the one person Id want by my side would be there. Ifelt safe. I wasnt scared anymore. But when you acted like you were out of the

loop, Ididn't know how to live. Iwondered if anything was even real anymore. Ithought Iwas stuck in this hell forever ."

"I understand. And Iwholly apologize, Enid."

"I know ." She smiled warmly . "It' s all right. Shit happens. But I choose to be with you regardless."

Unable to hold her gaze, W ednesday averted her eyes but held fast to Enid's hand. "I've never been someone' s." She trailed of f.

"Buddy? Best friend? Earnest love interest? Pal to my gal?"

"Favorite."

"What about—"

"In a way that mattered."

"Actually , can you say that again?" Enid exaggeratedly pulled out her phone as if to record a video. "This feels like a once-in-a-lifetime experience." She tugged on W ednesday's hand to catch her eyes before she could pull away. "But seriously , stuff like this is probably gonna keep happening between us. Being at *this* school, Ican almost guarantee it. We just have to be the ones to choose if it matters to stick by each other through it all."

"I've been this way my whole life," W ednesday admitted.

"I get that, and I'd never force you to change. That has to be your own choice, but life is about growing. The things we experience can hopefully lessen those seemingly eternal hurdles we put in front of ourselves. After a while, you may want to challenge them with a little help."

Wednesday narrowed her eyes. "Did you get that of f the Wellness Club brochure?"

"*No*," she said, insulted. "I went to their meetings for like a week last year. I only left because they started making blood pacts, and then the student advisor mysteriously vanished."

"You've piqued my interest. Remind me to check them out later."

"Oh, they were forced to disband after the club president was exposed for stealing everyone's life force. And something with credit fraud. It was a whole thing." She waved her hand dismissively. "But the advice still rings true."

"I'll keep that in mind. As much as I loath to admit it, my mother once said, despite my brilliance, I sometimes get in my own way. I've always found remorse to be a gateway trait that led to feelings which triggered tears."

"Which you don't do."

"Correct. Despite my family's meager reluctance, I refuse to play the role of a pawn in someone else's corrupt game of emotivity."

An image of The Addams Family flickered through Enid's mind. The completely head-over-heels couple, seemingly incapable of showing anything *but* emotion toward each other, left a strong impression on Enid.

"Your parents are so in love, though."

Wednesday didn't hide her umbrage. "Which is why it's so nauseating to think I could end up like them. Genetics, as I found, are incredibly powerful inducements."

Enid smiled cheekily. "You won't find me complaining."

"Well, you're easily amused."

"I know you mean it as an insult, but I'm *choosing* to hear it as *not that*. See how easy that is?"

"All I see is you falling into the psychological trap that is sentimentality." Wednesday furrowed her eyebrows as Enid looked at her with a tiny burgeoning smile on her face. "What?"

"You don't feel a hug coming on?"

Wednesday grimaced. "We've already kissed multiple times. I hoped we'd evolved past the need for hugs."

"*Evolved past the need…*" She could feel her cheeks reddening. "How can you just say that so *nonchalantly*?" she mumbled. "Wait, wait, does that mean I get free rein on kissing you now?"

Releasing her hand, Wednesday leveled her with a dower look and crossed her arms. "Define free rein."

"I know you're being obtuse on purpose because you're embarrassed, but not to worry, Enid Sinclair will kiss the pants off you." She stopped. "Now—wait. Not what I meant."

Wednesday hummed as she began walking back toward campus. "It seems what I've read about werewolves is true. Insightful."

"What do you mean?" Enid started to panic. "Wait, what did you read? Oh my god, Wednesday, is this how I find out you read trashy romance novels about werewolves?" She scrambled to keep pace. "You *gotta* tell me which ones! Personally, my favorite are the ones where,"—

Wednesday held a single finger to Enid's lips, silencing her. "Let's refocus, shall we?"

Enid resisted the urge to bite Wednesday's finger. "*Fine*. Let's *refocus*." She crouched and stalked ahead dramatically, speaking with a vaguely English accent. "*Time loops. Turmoil. Treachery. We meet back with our stunning heroines at an emotional crossroads. What adventures lie ahead of them now that their,*—"

"Enough."

"W ell? *Focus* ," she groaned. "T ell me you at least found something out. Ive just been sulking in bed, as you already know ."

"Unfortunately , my solo investigation has turned up empty."

She frowned. "A whole week?" She couldnt help the snark in her voice when she said, "All the lying and avoiding me, and you didnt even find out anything new? Cant say Im surprised." She buf fed her nails on her blaz er . "Karma is real and a bitch."

Wednesday sent a deadly glare her way. "I admit that my mind was addled. I was unfocused."

"Couldnt stop thinking about me, huh?" Enid meant it as a blatant joke, but when W ednesday only averted her eyes in silence, Enid suddenly didnt know where to look. "Oh, you really couldnt," she breathed out.

"In the spirit of growth I couldnt," W ednesday admitted.

Enid bit the inside of her lip to stop a giddy squeal in its tracks, then took a breath to calm herself. "As happy as it makes me to hear you admit it, if you pull any shit like this again, were done. For real this time."

"Understood." She nodded. "If it' s any consolation, the moment after I decided to independently continue, all I heard in my head was you and your impassioned haranguing, telling me what *friendship was* and that *I haven't learned anything.* "

"The things that cut through the deepest, haunt us the most." She grinned. "Why didnt you just come back? I mean, I basically yelled at you for something you already realized. W olf out aside, why didnt you stop me back then?

Wednesday sat on her response for a minute. "I was embarrassed. You are someone whose opinion I value above all others. And while I pride myself on my excellent hearing abilities, sometimes it begs to hear things twice."

Enid really tried to hamper down a smile this time but ended up unsuccessful. She decided to spare Wednesday of any more emotional reticence and change the subject.

"No visions, then?" Enid watched the way her friend's jaw clenched again. The smooth, pale planes of her face contracted in a hypnotizing w—

"None."

She cleared her throat. "Right."

"Though we can cross off death as a loop deterrent. There is something beyond the confines of nature that is keeping us here."

Enid stared straight at her roommate with polite incomprehension. "I'm sorry, it sounded like you implied you were experimenting with *dying*. Did I hear that right?"

Wednesday simply shrugged. "I used proper precaution."

"What the hell does that mean?"

"I had Thing on standby to resuscitate if necessary."

"If necessary?" Her voice pitched up with hysterics.

"Regardless, I waited until the end of a loop. There was no risk to my life."

"*Risk to your life*— but you didn't even know that for sure!" Enid was positive she was having a full-blown panic attack. "You didn't even try to kill someone else? What possessed you to try that alone?"

"I wasn't alone. Thing was with me."

"That is *so* not the point, and you know that."

"I'm sorry murder upsets you," Wednesday said as if that was the only reason.

"I'm sorry murder would upset *anyone*, Wednesday!"

"You already stated your disapproval for the idea," she explained, still even-tempered. "So I was right to wait until you thought we were no longer connected to make an attempt. My brother's faulty gift was good for something in the end." She huffed with dissatisfaction. "Torture devices were never his strong suit, especially theoretical ones. I was able to get it working properly in the end." There was a tender look in her eyes. "The Greeks had laudable imaginations. When we escape this time loop, remind me to brush up on my ancient mythology."

"Oh my god"…

"I'd rather not argue again," she said offhandedly. "Can we just brush over my observation that death is not an impediment?"

Enid was slack-jawed. "I think I'm having the horrifying realization that we can never fight again, or you're *literally* going to kill yourself."

"I've already attempted it once. The likelihood of it happening a second time is low."

"Actually, the word you're looking for is *nonexistent*." The enunciation of every syllable was dragged out to its fullest extent. "I can handle a lot from you, Wednesday, and I gladly want to, but this is wild even for you."

Wednesday looked at her coolly. "And?"

"*And* it deserves recompense. Personal injury lawyers don't exist for no reason."

She seemed to really think about it. "A kiss?"

"Suddenly you're *so eager*," Enid chided, not playing into Wednesday's game. "I know your schemes. It's cute you think kissing will get you out of this. No, I was thinking more along the lines of you helping me with my next dance routine."

Suddenly, Wednesday looked stricken. "Surely you're joking"…

"You enrolled after it passed," Enid started, a wicked grin growing on her face, "but the Solstice Talent show is *the* premiere event at Nevermore." She looped their arms together while Wednesday was dragged along in shock, thinking of the consequences of her action. "We can discuss the details later, but now that *The Time Loop Bandits* are back together—"

"No."

"I worked a long time on that," she whined.

Wednesday looked sick. "It's supremely banal. We're not *bandits*. We don't burgle."

"Look who's talking."

"Point taken, but I take it back immediately as my point still remains."

She tugged Wednesday's arm. "I thought it was cute."

"Try again. If you insist on doing this, then it needs to be original. We will not have a lame pseudonym."

"I can't just think of things on the fly. Who do you think I am— *The Time Traveler's Witch*!"

"Disgusting."

"*The Time Loop, the Witch, and the Werewolf*."

"I said original."

"A ww, I kinda like that one."

"The children never should have gone back. They were rulers of a high fantasy kingdom. I will not be named in the same breath as those idiots."

Enid's brow furrowed. "That' s not the message of wh whatever . Okay," she thought for a moment. "*Back to the Time b bop* ."

"No."

"*b boper* ."

"Y ou're j just naming movie titles."

"I'm surprised you even know any of these." W ednesday's immediate lack of retort spoke volumes to Enid. "W ait, did you *watch* movies? Please tell me you watched a time travel movie!"

She attempted to unhook their arms, but Enid held steadfast. Wednesday rolled her eyes. "I may have told Thing to watch some for propriety."

Enid bit down on her bottom lip to stop herself from s squealing. The other girl was obviously trying to look uninterested. "Y ou're making it really hard for me not to kiss you right now," she admitted with a wide smile.

"Are you done?"

"No, wait! I can't think that fast!"

"T onight well workshop it."

Enid gave herself a high five and peeked at the tiniest hint of a smile on Wednesday's face.

They walked off toward their dorm, Enid giggling quietly to herself. Wednesday was still smiling ever so faintly when they reached their door and shuffled inside.

LOVE

The feeling of being woken up by birdsong she'd heard dozens of times was suddenly the sweetest sound Enid could have ever dreamt up.

Incapable of wiping the smile from her face, she immediately locked eyes with Wednesday across the room, who only groaned quietly to herself.

Wednesday scowled. "Your incessant cheer is giving me heartburn. I liked it better when you hid under the covers at the sight of me."

"Good morning to you, too." Enid made sure to flash an even brighter smile in Wednesday's direction. Despite the other girl's outward disdain, she would have put down money to prove the usual pale complexion of her roommate had maybe the slightest hint of color spread across her cheeks.

As if reading her thoughts, Wednesday's head began to bow slightly. A stray cloud blocked the sun for a moment, and the shadows it cast seemed to drape her in a subtle cloak of consuming darkness. Her eyes glowed eerily like a monster at the edge of a dark forest, waiting to consume any unfortunate soul that passed by.

Enid pursed her lips together, not sure if the other girl was readily plotting her demise or wanting to strike Enid's heart with her uncanny beauty. The high probability of the former being true over the latter was delightfully ignored. "You're being spooky again."

"Good." The other girl's frown deepened more prominently than normal. "Never forget that."

Enid sighed lightly. "So what's the plan today? We kind of struck out the last couple days with those mock interview sessions with the other students, and I really don't want to go through that again."

"Yes." Wednesday made a face. "I was unaware how many people were going to use them as impromptu therapy sessions. It was… harrowing. Do I give off the sense of a counselor who wants to listen to people bemoan their daily lives?"

"You have a very calming demeanor. People are drawn to that."

"Too many, unfortunately. I will not make that mistake again." Immediately, Wednesday was all business. "We desperately need information. As a girl with obvious obsessive investigative tendencies—"

"Say that five times fast."

"I have failed miserably in that regard. To be an effective detective, one needs to make informed decisions. Informed decisions require sufficient intel. And *that* has been our downfall."

"Yeah, our intel is lacking because we don't even know where to start." The understatement of the century, Enid thought. Once they got out of this—*because she refused to believe they weren't*—Enid was never going to complain about having to sit through a boring class lecture ever again. "So, back to the library?"

She nodded. "I have a working theory that this phenomenon is too localized to be from an outside source. And as far as you know, you don't possess any enemies."

"I'm just a girl!"

"As you've said." Wednesday shook her head disdainfully. "It still doesn't mean this wasn't a targeted attack."

She hated the sound of that. "Targeted to who, then? And why?"

"*Whom*," Wednesday corrected. "And that's what we need to find out."

Enid made a face. "So your theory is that this whole thing has either been some kind of sick prank or something more malicious? That really narrows down things." She sucked her teeth and mumbled, "I could've told you that"…

"I don't have enough conclusive evidence to state either or but I always tend to lean towards the malevolent. Humanity is a depraved species, and intentions rarely end as they begin."

"So what? Do you think someone is targeting our dorm room?"

"Or Ophelia Hall as a whole."

She tried to wrap her head around that. "Fantastic..."

"What?"

"If this entire thing has been a giant hoax for someone else and we got roped into it, me especially, I'm gonna be beyond pissed. Talk about an innocent bystander! What did I do to deserve this?"

"You're just a girl," Wednesday obliged.

"Exactly!" There was a spark of fire in her eyes. Enid balled her hands into tight fists. "We're figuring this out. Are you with me?"

"I already stated I am."

"I'm trying to hype up the energy, silly. Keep us motivated."

"I'm already motivated. Why is more motivation necessary?"

Enid deflated. "I know you like being difficult on purpose, but it's literally not needed now."

Wednesday smirked slightly, turning away. "I don't know what you mean."

"Sure," she mumbled.

The library remained unchanged.

Enid would've been worried otherwise, but it was honestly becoming a sore spot for her. After an hour of aimless historical research on Nevermore, Enid suspected her roommate may have been grasping at straws. As the seconds passed by, she idly wondered how much trouble she'd get in if she just started tearing all the books to shreds.

On the other hand, Wednesday, still of a one-track mind, plopped down at their table and, for the barest moment, stared at her book without seeing it before quickly refocusing herself.

Despite the other girl's abhorrence for displaying emotion, Enid could see that the past frustrations of previous loops still weighed on her. She adjusted her seat to reach over and place her hand over Wednesday's. The other girl didn't flinch or move away, so she called it a win.

"I get that we're pretty much at the end of our rope," said Enid, "but are you sure we should be focusing on historic issues? Here me out how do we know this isn't some rando turning our lives to shit for fun? Nevermore isn't very popular with normies and you pissed of f a lot of them last year. By association, they could be going after us."

Wednesday clenched her hand and smoothly slipped it out from under Enid's gasp. "I'll take your suggestion into consideration, but I refuse to move on until proven otherwise. If anyone knew I failed to get the job done, I would feel terrible."

"More terrible than being stuck in a time loop indefinitely?"

"Yes."

I'm dying to know why."

"I want to impress you," Wednesday said plainly.

There was something deeply attractive about having someone outright say what they meant without any hidden meaning. It was at least one reason why she fell for Wednesday in the first place.

The desire to kiss the other girl again shifted her attentions so she said as much. "I really want to kiss you again."

Wednesday locked eyes with her for a beat, seemingly contemplating, before averting her gaze. "Your lack of rousing subtlety is noted. We're in the middle of an investigation. The time for frivolities will come later."

Enid failed at smothering a flirtatious smile. "So you're saying there's a *later*?"

Wednesday reached for another book. "I'm saying—" She gasped sharply as her head threw itself backwards. Her body instantly grew stiff as her eyes impossibly widened, staring at nothing.

"Holy shit!" Enid scrambled to catch Wednesday's body before the girl could hit the ground. Thankfully, they were sequestered to a corner in the back of the library, far away from the vicious eyes of the moody librarian, so they had some privacy.

She took Wednesday's lithe form in her arms, steadying her and gently laid them both down to the ground, using her lap as a pillow for the other girl's head. A fierce bout of protectiveness washed over Enid as her roommate lay in her lap at her most vulnerable.

With a careful touch, she gingerly straightened Wednesday's bangs back in neat order as the girl started to stir. Dark eyes blinked slowly as awareness began to set back in. A sudden chill shuddered through her body as clarity fully came back to her eyes.

Worried that the other girl would move immediately, Enid tried not to make their positioning obvious. But to her surprise, Wednesday only shifted slightly as if to get more comfortable as she gathered her thoughts.

"Are you wearing a new perfume?" she finally asked.

Enid shook her head slowly, trying her best to keep still. "No."

Wednesday hummed and said nothing else. Her mind was still clearly working out her vision.

"What did you see?" Enid tried to be as nonchalant as possible, but could hear the awkward strain in her voice.

"It was strange," she replied after a moment. "My visions didn't feel as visceral as previous times. It was disappointing."

"Didn't you say you were looking into the past of your ancestor? Maybe your visions were hi-def because of it?" Enid could see the gears turning in Wednesday's mind.

"It's possible. Until I train more with the limits of my power, it's all just speculation. Regardless, I did see two young men."

"Colonial-era stuff again?" Enid asked with a grimace, trying very hard not to reach out and brush the out-of-place hairs on Wednesday's forehead. "If a pilgrim tries to burn us all alive again, I say we just cut our losses and learn to live in a time loop for the rest of eternity."

"I have no desire to live in arrested development. Nor should you," she chastised. "No, this vision was set much more modern. If I had to estimate, I'd say maybe the late 60s or early 70s."

Enid's face lit up. "Vintage!"

"They seemed to be arguing about something, but I couldn't hear a word of it. It was as if I were placed behind a bubble of muffled

sound." Wednesday continued trying to piece together the vision in her mind. "Whatever it was they were arguing about was getting to a tipping point before a random passerby interrupted, and they left. My vision ended then."

"Teenage boys fighting? Great," she said mockingly, "how are we ever gonna figure that one out?"

"At least I know their faces," Wednesday said as she began to push herself up off the ground. "I'll sketch them out as best as I can for you. We can start there. Thankfully, I recognized one of the classrooms at school and the fact that they were wearing a version of Nevermore's uniforms."

"Yearbook party!" Enid exclaimed, suddenly keen on the idea of more research. Dusting off their clothing, a realization hit her so suddenly that it almost knocked her back onto the floor. "*I never would have figured that out*," she whispered with shock and awe. "There's literally no conceivable way I'd have known to look for something like that. Holy shit, *Wednesday*, I would've been stuck in here forever without you."

The horror that could have befallen her struck all at once. The very real reality that she would have been trapped in this time loop for an eternity with no way out...

Wednesday remained silent. The acknowledgment that Enid's words were true was deafening. She was her lifeline—her partner in this crazy mystery, and she would've been lost in her absence.

"Oh my god," she breathed out, then made a grab for the other girl's arm. Brows furrowed and eyes glistening, her fingers gripped tightly around her bicep. She pulled Wednesday in for a hug, slow enough that the other girl could pull away easily if she wanted. But she didn't. Enid pressed the side of her face against the top of Wednesday's head. "Thank you," she whispered. "I'm still kind of pissed at you but you know"…

Wednesday tensed a fraction, then relaxed almost immediately against her arms with a small exhale. "Like you've said previously: We work. We shouldn't—"

"But we do," Enid finished and then kissed the crown of Wednesday's head.

"A weird anomaly."

They slowly untangled themselves but still remained in each other's space. "Sorry about the hug."

"I'll let this one slide," said Wednesday. "It's an innovative kind of torture."

"Should I be writing this down? Your preferences are kind of new territory for me, but I'm willing to learn. I *want* to learn."

"Writing is useless until we escape these loops, but I admire the sadism."

Enid looked at her, confused. "I don't think that's what that means."

Wednesday chuckled darkly. "You'll learn."

"You know that tone freaks me out!" She shuddered. "Whatever, let's just move on."

"Sure."

"Okay, so as you know, the librarian is in a pissy mood and won't let us check out books. I think we have a good hour before it closes, so we'll have to be sneaky with smuggling anything out." She began to head to the yearbook section before Wednesday's words stopped her.

"We don't have to do this immediately. We can start next loop."

Enid jumped in a dramatic fashion, eyes practically bulging out of her head. "Wednesday Addams not wanting to dive headfirst into a new discovery? Are you ill?" She reached for her forehead, but her hand was immediately batted away.

"I don't want to push you." Wednesday spun on her heel, arms crossed. "I'm attempting at mindfulness."

No longer fearful of giving in to impulse, Enid slowly rounded on her roommate. Reaching out, she gently cupped the other girl's cheek and slowly leaned forward to press her lips to the other side. She pulled back with a wide smile, satisfied at the sight of the obvious ruddy coloration spreading across Wednesday's face.

"That's really sweet of you," Enid started, "but it's been like thirty-something days. I'm sick of this bitch. A lead is a lead. Let's follow it! There's still a couple hours before restart, we should take advantage of it."

"Then I rescind my offer," Wednesday said quietly.

"So what do you think?" Enid skipped over to an adjacent section of the library as Wednesday naturally trailed behind her. "Should we start early 70s or late 70s or... maybe we go from the middle outward?"

Compared to previous times, this was probably the easiest research session the two of them had ever attempted. Looking through yearbooks was as low-stakes as it got. At least to Enid, it was a degree more pleasant than what she'd become accustomed to. Wednesday wasn't stressed, Enid didn't feel like the world was constantly on the edge of imploding. Neither of them was secretly worried about the other.

She could almost pretend it felt like a normal day.

"Yahtzee," Wednesday mildly exclaimed.

"If it's another murder, I'll pass," Enid said wearily, unimpressed with Wednesday's priorities. "Nevermore has more of an issue than I thought. They should really disclose this in the admissions packet."

"Bureaucracy is its own lie. Look at this."

"What?" Enid glanced over Wednesday's shoulder as she pointed at a candid picture of a fencing club photo. In the background was a student looking off to the side, seemingly in the middle of a laugh, looking very similar to the picture Wednesday drew for reference, if not a bit younger.

"It's definitely one of the boys I saw in my vision."

"I agree, but someone definitely doesn't like him." The photo was vandalized by a red marker, giving the boy a curly mustache and monocle, coupled with unflattering buck teeth and tiny horns on his head.

"At least we have a name. Idrin. It's written in the margin."

In faded red pen, a sentence is scratched out: *Idrin is a cheese eater!*

"Cheese?"

"It means brownnoser," Wednesday explained. "For someone who prides themselves on knowing what's *in style,* you sure don't know a lot about the evolution of language. You have to expose yourself to different eras of knowledge to truly round out your expertise."

"I know about *this* century. Slang terms from the 70s are not exactly in my purview of social learning." She smiled cheekily. "That's what I have you for."

Wednesday glanced at Enid's watch. "At least we have a better grasp of what time frame to search through. We'll take these yearbooks and explore them thoroughly tonight and tomorrow. Then

well go into town and look up historical records at City Hall. Specifically, any pertaining to incidents with Nevermore students."

"Will they just let us look through stuff like that? I'm not so knowledgeable on how things are saved in the public record. Especially anything dealing with Outcasts."

"There is always documentation, regardless of background. The only issue we may face going to City Hall is the staff's vehement dislike of me. I'm hoping your disposition will ease them over."

Enid folded her hands together. "You're saying you need me to shmooze?"

"Yes."

"Say no more." She offered her hand to Wednesday. "Come on, it's getting late, and we should head to dinner. I've been promising Yoko I'd eat with her for weeks and have been blowing her off. Not that she knows that"…

Wednesday took her hand cautiously. "I refuse to engage in any gossiping."

"Wouldn't dream you would. All you need to do is stay on my arm and look pretty." She winked.

"A trophy wife. How did I stoop so low"…

LOSS

Like a haunted scarecrow with neatly braided pigtails, Wednesday awkwardly perched at the foot of Enid's bed as the girl frantically rummaged through her dresser.

With a delighted squeal, Enid peeked over her shoulder. Mischievousness glinted in her eyes, making Wednesday flinch a

single step back. "I know you don't like school spirit..."

"It's a tribal adolescent cliche," said Wednesday.

"*But,* since we finally have a lead, we're not going to figure out anything if we don't put ourselves in Odrin's shoes. And since I firmly believe in the power of fashion, I thought we should play the part. Wednesday Addams." There was a rustle of fabric as she held up two rainbow colored articles of clothing. "Do you want to borrow my leg warmers?"

Wednesday walked out the door.

"Oh my god, it was a joke. Don't leave me!"

Enid had gone to Jericho only a handful of times, so arriving with Wednesday felt like a breath of fresh air. She knew the basic schedule of routines in town but without the extreme personal attachment, as with Nevermore, Enid could almost pretend she'd finally escaped the time loop.

The feeling that she was on the knife's edge of anticipation with every step she took on campus was supremely diminished while walking down the street here. It was liberating.

"It's gotta mean something that I'm not freaking out over attempting to break into a government building." Despite her words, Enid's head was on a swivel, watching for any potential law enforcement as Wednesday searched for a back door into City Hall.

It turned out that Enid did not have to shmooze anyone. City Hall happened to be closed for the day, so the next obvious step was to find a way to break in.

Wednesday found a door hidden in a side alley. "Didn't you say you practiced delinquency in your first week of loops?"

"Yeah, but all I did was sneak into the teachers' lounge and break a few windows." She paused, considering. "Maybe I've lost all sense of self-preservation."

"Unlikely. Your knees are shaking." With an annoyed grunt, Wednesday pulled her lockpicking tools out of the door she was working on. The ends bits were worn and mangled. "This is the last time I order from third-party distribution centers. *Durable steel*," she scoffed, "even I could tell the metal work was shoddy."

Enid rapped her knuckles against the iron door. It sounded hollow. "Maybe I can give it a go?"

Wednesday dutifully stepped aside.

Hands locked firmly around the doorknob, Enid took a second to center herself, then channeled a fraction of her supernatural strength and pulled. A grating scraping of metal screeched through the silent back alley as Enid felt the weathered iron hinges bend against her strength. All at once, the door broke off its hinges and fell open violently.

Stumbling back on her heels, Enid almost fell before managing to level her foot against the ground to push the door back in place where it unceremoniously slumped to one side, completely broken.

Not at all looking at the door, Wednesday seemed to stand straighter. "That was impressive."

Enid tossed her hair flirtatiously and winked. "You can just say it was hot, I know."

Barely resisting a fond eye roll, Wednesday quickly pulled them both into the darkened interior of the building and led them down a few levels of stairs toward a back corner room that smelled of musty paper and old ink. She wasted no time pulling a few boxes off of the shelves, gesturing for Enid to do the same.

“Hopefully , the records of the years we’re looking for haven’t been digitized. Though I have hopes that the Jericho municipal government does not prioritize modernization in any form.”

“What happens if what we’re looking for is digitized?”

“Then we unfortunately waste time breaking into a government-protected computer. Which is not in my repertoire of skills.”

Enid grimaced, then tore through the box in front of her . Old newspapers and public record forms were in abundance, all date-stamped from the late 80s. She showed Wednesday. “Guess they’re more concerned with terrorizing Outcasts than keeping their records accessible.”

An hour quickly passed in the low-lit room as the two of them searched through old editions of the local newspapers looking for anything pertaining to Nevermore or Outcast-related incidents in the 1970s.

It was mind-numbing work, but for Enid, it felt good to finally have a clear focus—at least for a little while.

After finishing another disappointing stack of papers, Enid looked over to her companion across the table. Wednesday seemed to be in her element. Head bowed, shoulders slightly hunched, eyes speedily scanning the text as her lips faintly muttered the words aloud. She was the picture of pinpoint focus; an attractive quality to be witness to.

Enid tried to jokingly imitate Wednesday’s demeanor, but could summon no real malice; it was difficult to disdain a girl who so clearly adored the accumulation of knowledge for knowledge’s sake.

Another hour passed.

“Gotta be nice not to have impending doom surround the mystery this time, huh?” Enid said, trying to distract her growing fatigue with

small talk.

Wednesday briefly glanced up from her reading to acknowledge the attention. "I wouldn't be so hasty. We haven't ruled it out completely yet. Sometimes the unexpected doom is more compelling."

"Right. I forgot who I was talking to," she said flatly.

"That being said," Wednesday looked at her pointedly, "this situation doesn't need any added doom. What you've experienced so far I would class as a slow kind of torture—a dilatory doom."

"Dilatory doom. Dilatory doom. Catchy, but I don't think I like you describing it that way."

Wednesday continued as if not hearing her. "The slow, impending torment of your entrapment would bring madness of the mind. It would gradually chip away at your psyche until you were brought so low into desperation that you'd slowly start to go insane. And with enough time in the simulated isolation, you eventually wouldn't be able to recognize our classmates or even me. Your werewolf fish instincts will have taken over and made it so you'd become so desperate for any sense of new connection that you'd probably start killing just to feel anything. Soon enough, the warm blood of your friends dripping down your body would replace the feeling of your own humanity. By the end of—"

Enid clamped her hands over her ears and started humming loudly. "Nope, nope, nope. Enough with serial murder fantasy. You're gonna give me nightmares!"

Satisfied, Wednesday smirked to herself as she turned back to the newspapers.

Another hour.

Glancing over at Wednesday periodically did nothing to alleviate her middling temper. Enid thought that after these couple of weeks

together—especially the last few days, and the subtle hints of mutual attraction, they would've maybe made more progress in the area of their romantic relationship. Not that Enid was expecting anything too forward, but there was only so much dancing around the topic she could tolerate before she would go mad.

Labels weren't something she necessarily subscribed to, but labels also meant everything in the world of teenagedom. And Enid, like any other girl who was invested in the social and political aspects of such, couldn't help but frantically obsess over them.

Or maybe she was looking at this all wrong. Maybe this *was* Wednesday's idea of a relationship. This very experience could have been her version of a date, since emotions weren't necessarily her thing. Maybe Enid was the one who had to measure her expectations.

She tested it.

"So," Enid attempted to slick her hair back in a graceful manner, "Come here often?"

Wednesday didn't look up. "I am an infrequent visitor of City Hall."

"Right. Should've guessed that..." She slumped in her chair and tapped a slow rhythm on the table as she lazily glanced around the room for some other form of relationship test.

"Enid."

"Yes?" Something in her back cracked with how fast she straightened up.

"Can you reach that stack on the top shelf over there?"

"Sure, I got it."

"Thanks."

Another hour.

"We could take these newspapers and go somewhere more cozy."

Wednesday started at her as if she'd grown a second head. "Do you not want this investigation to move as efficiently as possible? All our reference material is here."

"Silly me..." Enid bit her bottom lip and breathed through her nose. Maybe the situation called for a strong arm; her escapades with Ajax came to mind. She clicked her teeth together. "You know I've been trying to flirt with you for the last couple hours, right?"

"I know," she said, plainly. "You're being incredibly obvious about it." And left it at that.

Enid wasn't sure how to respond without further falling into her indignity, so she let the matter die before her ego suffered.

Obviously, the hours of research weren't weighing on Wednesday like they were on Enid.

Enid swore her eyesight was blurring the more she stared at these old newspapers. If she had to read about another county fair or holiday parade ending in a *surprising tragedy*, she would be tempted to find a similar *surprising tragedy* for herself, the longer this went on.

The thought to voice her grievances came at the exact moment the other girl pushed another stack of newspapers in front of her. Enid groaned at the black-and-white script that was starting to bend and shift together the more she stared at it.

Slumping half over the table in defeat, Enid mumbled, "This is officially the worst date ever." Then plucked one from the middle of the stack and opened it randomly. Something immediately caught her eye.

“Adrian Gornum!” she shouted excitedly, waving the newspaper in the air. “Adrian Gornum! I found them! Nevermore Academy Class of 1972. Wait, ’72? We definitely checked that yearbook, right?” She paused, confused. “I don’t remember seeing him at all. Did we miss something? What else happened that year?”

“1972.” Wednesday laid the materials in her hand down and stared off in the distance. “It’s the last year the *Young People’s Concerts* were telecast. You can attribute Leonard Bernstein to my burgeoning love for classical music, as it can be traced back to those syndicated concerts.”

“Strange fact to know off the top of your head.”

Wednesday shrugged. “In an effort to bond with me, my mother would play reruns of the episodes, and we’d watch them together. A fine knowledge and appreciation for the arts is very important to my family.”

“That’s actually really adorable.”

“I would make time to watch episodes in between Pugsley torture sessions. Whatever the episode focused on, I skewed the demo to that composer’s country of origin. Pugsley would then attempt to construct an explosive device native to their area as well. It really expanded my repertoire. I’m very grateful for it.”

“A little *less* adorable but still very on brand for you. Strange that your brother’s never mentioned that before.”

“What do you mean?”

Enid looked proud of herself. “Didn’t you know? Your brother and I are texting buddies,” she said flippantly. “*Kind of.* He mostly just asks how you’re doing and talks about how much he misses you. He’s surprisingly sentimental.”

Wednesday stared at her, mouth slightly agape. "Is this what they mean by getting to know your in-laws?"

Even though she knew it was a joke, Enid still clutched at her chest and released a choked squeal of surprise. "I really didn't expect you to make so many jokes."

"I contain multitudes," Wednesday said smugly, then changed the subject. "What's the paper say?"

Enid looked back at the article after catching her breath. "It's so—oh damn. It's an obituary." She slid over the paper so Wednesday could read it.

Idrin Ornum, 17, a bright-eyed dreamer and fencing enthusiast, passed away last week. Idrin packed a lifetime of love and laughter into his short years. Known for his infectious smile and boundless talent, Idrin had a unique ability to brighten even the gloomiest days. Idrin's kindness was legendary among his classmates. He is survived by his parents and a community of friends whose lives he touched deeply.

"Still doesn't sense why we didn't find much trace of him at school," Enid said with a frown.

"Classic Nevermore tactic. Cover up the details of a student's death. What else is new?" Wednesday peered closer at the faded photo attached below the obituary. "That's the other boy I saw in my vision. It looks like they're in the cemetery outside campus."

"Eww." Enid made a face. "So his body is just at the school?"

"No," Wednesday said, and Enid relaxed. "Decomposition would have already taken him. Though I don't know what embalming practices Nevermore acquiesced in the past. Could be a skeleton, could be a mostly decaying corpse. There's only one way to make sure."

"Gross." She sighed loudly. "Looks like I spoke too soon about the murdering. But," she added quickly, "this isn't technically happening to us, so it doesn't count." Wednesday didn't respond, and Enid looked over to see a deranged smile slowly grow on the other girl's face. Dread slammed into Enid's chest. Her stomach bottomed out, and she forced herself to sit. "Don't say it"…

"We have to dig up a body."

Enid wailed. "No!"

It didn't surprise her in the least, but Enid still tried not to think about how efficiently her roommate could dig out a grave with little preparation.

It wasn't a skill she thought many people had, but the proficiency with which Wednesday got to work to exhume a body was borderline inspiring and only a little bit odd. But the amount of gross dirt under her nails was not something Enid wished to ever live with.

"Nonsense," Wednesday said, slightly affronted. To pass the time, the two girls had struck up a conversation and somehow landed on the hypothetical scenario if Enid had approached Wednesday earlier in the time loop. "After enough loops, I would have given you a strict set of instructions to impart that would have led me to believe you immediately, no matter the circumstance."

"But you're so suspicious of *everything*." Enid threw her hands up. She sat on the edge of the excavated grave, legs dangling over the side, taking a break as Wednesday finished out the job. "I think you underestimate yourself and my ability to *impart* information."

"Don't you have a love of performing?"

"In my experience, confidence is key to being a great actor, and you're super judgmental. *And* mutually exclusive."

Wednesday sported an annoyed frown as she continued digging before a loud thunk was heard as she struck something with her shovel.

"Please be a skeleton, please be a skeleton," Enid chanted as the other girl cleared away the dirt.

"There's nothing here." Wednesday stepped aside so Enid could see the skeleton-less coffin interior.

"Wait, what does that mean?"

"Why else does anyone bury an empty casket and not disclose that information to the public?" Sleeves half rolled up and numerous smudges of dirt across her body, Wednesday stared down at the empty coffin under her feet with clear dissatisfaction in her stance. "There wasn't a body to bury. Knowing this school, they tried to cover their collective asses."

Enid cringed. "The longer I'm here, the more I think I'd be lucky to graduate and not die."

"I wouldn't let that happen."

"As much as I'd love to swoon over your romance novel delivery, *you're* the one most surrounded by death. I've put myself directly in harm's way."

"Yet you remain by my side."

Enid playfully rolled her eyes but smiled down at her roommate fondly. "We all have our flaws." She stared at the empty coffin, then glanced back at Wednesday, a thought coming to her mind. "Did you want to get in it?" she asked hesitantly.

Enid didn't think she'd seen anything closer to love in the other girl's eyes than in that moment.

"Just five minutes." There was an edge of giddiness in her tone. "Then help me out." Wednesday scrambled into the coffin and closed it without waiting for Enid's answer.

Enid had to wonder if this was how her life was to be now. Midnight graveyard raids with her roommate who she didn't know if they were officially dating or not, stuck in a time loop while investigating the life of someone half a century dead. If that wasn't the definition of *head over heels,* then she may have to reevaluate some things.

The five minutes moved along quickly, and before long, Enid hopped down into the hole, landing on the coffin with sturdy footing. With little effort, she opened the casket to the uncanny visage of Wednesday Addams looking every bit as dead as the appearance gave.

Then, as if awaking from a deep slumber, dark eyes opened slowly and shone with brilliant clarity even in the darkness. "We'll have to go underground."

Enid whimpered uncomfortably, nerves immediately fraying at the thought of venturing beneath the school. "We will?"

So close to the end of the loop, the two girls decided to stay out in the graveyard and wait it out, more so at Wednesday's behest.

While lying in the casket, Wednesday had a vision of Ishtar stalking around campus in the night before finding his way through a secret passage leading to a series of tunnels underground.

It wasn't that Enid didn't trust Wednesday's visions, but going underground meant dangerous unknowns and tight, dreary spaces. Neither of which appealed to her in the slightest.

"May I ask why?" Wednesday suddenly asked, breaking Enid's internal agitation.

"Why what?" She flinched back, unaware that Wednesday had taken perch next to her at the edge of the grave. She could see every glisten of sweat and smudge of dirt that clung to her face and neck.

"Why you kissed me the first time."

Enid laughed awkwardly at the abrupt shift of topic. "Why does anyone kiss anyone these days?" Wednesday stared at her patiently. Enid cleared her throat. "I don't know. Call it what you want… Hormones? Teenage angst? Desperation? I told you I liked you," she explained weakly. "I mean, *you* kissed *me,* too, right? What's *your* reasoning?"

"That was out of momentary necessity. My research about werewolves stated that a strong emotional stimulus can halt a wolf out in its tracks. Not a true wolf out, mind you, but it was proven effective."

Enid was not sure how she liked that kiss being described as a *necessity*. "Hold on, you researched werewolves over the break?" Wednesday shot her a glare. "Right, not the point. We *are* talking about that later, though. Sorry, continue."

"Actually, I was asking you, and you avoided the question. So, in your words, desperation led you to kiss me?"

"Sure?"

"You would have done that to anyone who crossed your path at that moment?"

This was dangerous territory, but she took the bait anyway. "No."

Wednesday leaned forward a little and angled her head impossibly close to Enid's. Lips almost touching. Enid lost all coherent thought. Any small movement forward from either of them would be all it took.

"You said, '*You won't remember this, and I don't know what I have to lose at this point.*'" Her voice lifted and shook in an almost exact tonal replication of when Enid uttered those exact words less than a month ago.

Wednesday's hand rose up to cup her cheek and seemed to contemplate leaning forward, but pulled back the next second, her face just a smidge off from her regular neutral. Clearly affected by her own actions.

Enid felt like her heart was about to burst out of her chest. She was sure anyone within a mile radius could hear her heartbeat.

"By your admission, that is what you claim to be desperation?" Wednesday made no subtle show that her attention wasn't expressly split between holding Enid's gaze and glancing at her mouth. "You offered yourself to kiss me twice after that."

"Yeah."

"Have you kissed anyone else during the loops?"

"You know I haven't."

Wednesday hummed. "Interesting."

"I'm scared to ask why that's interesting." Her voice was embarrassingly strained.

"Your *desperation* seems to have a type." Then Wednesday smiled. A sight not many could say they witnessed firsthand.

Enid stuttered through a string of incoherent words. "*I think I'm having a heart attack.*" Like all the bones in her body had liquified, Enid slid down into the grave and leaned against the side, her chest heaving violently.

Wednesday jumped down to loom over her. She placed a hand above Enid's head on the wall of dirt to anchor herself. The shadows

over her face painted a mosaic of exalted beauty before her. Enid could feel every pulse of her heart through every vein and vessel in her body as Wednesday regarded her curiously.

"Not likely," said Wednesday. "True cardiac arrest may stem from your arm to your neck." She traced the length of Enid's arm from the wrist to the shoulder using the barest brush of her fingertips. "Shortness of breath and lightheadedness."

"Uh"...

Wednesday amusedly leaned back a bit, giving Enid a chance to breathe.

"Spending time here on a clear night, inside a hollowed grave of our making has forced me to evaluate some things," Wednesday started saying, dropping a bit of the bravado to earnestly address Enid. "I may lack the social norms of people our age, but I've also been witness to my parents' relationship my entire life. The last few days, you have essentially taken the lead on your attraction towards me, and while I have yet to rebuff your affections, I've also realized that I never quite stated my position on them."

The words just burst out. "Are you breaking up with me? *Sorry*. Sorry, continue."

She exhaled softly. "Knowing that you like to be direct about intention when approaching things of this nature." Wednesday's face slightly contorted as if she were overcoming some intrinsic difficulty, but then relaxed. "I like you, Enid. Despite everything about you. Despite whatever social faux pas I may inevitably facilitate that potentially pushes you away. My attraction to you remains thus."

Enid wasn't sure if it was because she knew what to expect now or because Wednesday initiated it—or because they were in the strangest place for this kind of thing to happen—but kissing Wednesday Addams felt distinctively familiar this time around. Every sense was heightened, every wanton emotion seemed amplified.

She felt every small shift of movement as Wednesday gingerly pressed her lips against hers.

Enid kissed her softly, positioning herself even closer, responding in turn to every one of the other girl's movements. One hand pulled down Wednesday to a more agreeable angle for her neck while the other caressed one side of her face. Then, in a surprising twist, it was Wednesday who parted her lips first, and a whole host of other sensations exploded.

Then nothing.

Like so many times before, Enid's world inexplicably faded to darkness as the alarm on her watch rang out.

LATER

"You—you did that on purpose!" The first words out of Enid's mouth were embarrassingly unsteady. The dredges of false sleep and Wednesday's bewitching closeness still addled her mind.

"I was only following your example." Wednesday innocently began her morning routine, not at all impaired like Enid was. One could say there was even a little bit of *pep* in her step. "It's quite fun to be on the other side of this. I see the appeal."

"That is *so* not fair."

"No one said this relationship would be fair."

"I don't think I'm going to *survive* this relationship." Despite her jest, Enid would ride the high of that implication for the rest of the day. Changing the subject, now that she was sufficiently more awake, she said, "You know, I'm proud of us."

"Why?"

"Despite the entire fiasco, there's been no mortal peril, not a one."

Wednesday smiled wickedly. It was as unsettling as it was enchanting. "Oh, Enid, now you've gone and jinxed it. I look forward to seeing what misfortune you've laid upon us now."

Enid whimpered. "I take it back, that's not what I meant."

"Too late. You've spoken it into existence." She bowed her head. "I'm honored to have been your last and final kiss."

"You should be."

"Do you want a knife?" she asked abruptly. In under a minute, Wednesday had procured no less than a dozen knives of varying shape and size spread out across her desk.

A sleek stiletto was being offered to Enid. The grip was bright pink, which made her think the other girl may have gotten it specifically for her. "When did you get this?"

"I've had it in my collection for less than a year. It's yours if you wish."

"Okay." Ignoring the *deadly weapon* of it all, she took the knife without thinking and slipped it into her pocket. "How many knives do you have hidden around our home—hold on, is the axe really necessary?" Wednesday slowly turned with an incredulous look on her face, her trusty axe already securely clipped to her belt. "A knife is one thing, but I feel like that's just putting a sign out to the universe that we *want* to be attacked."

A fierce scowl and silence was the other girl's answer. She made a theatrical show of dropping the axe on her desk, then bowed toward the door in a *lead the way* gesture. Enid rolled her eyes, and together they headed out.

"So the conservatory *should* be empty," Enid said once they approached the outside of the wide building. "We should be okay to go in. No one really bothers coming here during the day in my experience, and campus security doesn't check in until after sunset." Despite her easy attitude, Enid still glanced around cautiously while Wednesday waltzed in with no regard for subtlety.

The aftermath of the *actual* previous school day's mishap was glaringly apparent. The usually opulent window-lined building was shuttered and sectioned off where the explosion of growth of one plant extended to an insane degree, breaking the glass walls and continuing out onto the path outside.

"My vision showed us in crawl through an area that looked like an outdoor garden, but as I recall, there is no open-air section in the building." Wednesday looked to her for guidance.

"Yeah, I was thinking about that last night, and I'm almost certain that's the renovated expansion they made in the early aughts. Yoko told me that one year they hosted the Raven inside the Conservatory, so I'm pretty sure it might be related."

"Whose inane idea was that?"

"I think they were trying to do an Earth Day theme." She chuckled when Wednesday groaned in disgust. "Yeah, so they built up the mini greenhouse section to accommodate the dance that year. Honestly? I see the vision," she said, impressed. "Maybe we should bring this up to the committee to try again this year."

"You do that and you'll be attending the dance alone."

Enid squealed. "Please tell me you basically just agreed to be my date for this year's Raven!"

"There will be no dance if we don't first escape this time loop."

"Right!" Enid glanced around one last time and slipped inside.

The few lanterns that hung from the high ceiling interior made lazy circles above the conservatory's ground floor, creating optical shadows amongst the dense flora that overran it. Without the normal buzz of other students, Enid felt like she was walking deep into a dense jungle that just happened to be built around a classroom. The abundance of exotic towering plants looked queer and disturbing in the deserted eeriness lit by washes of brittle white light from the hanging lanterns.

The hidden hatch that Enid stumbled upon early on in her loops was well hidden by a few heavy pots, but with Wednesday's help were moved aside easily. She whined quietly as they spied the ladder that led to the depths underneath Nevermore.

"Into the dark we go"…

Every rung of the ladder was both ice cold and strangely warm, giving greater oddity to the already creepy nature of their spelunking. Before long, Enid had two solid feet on the ground and a loose grip on Wednesday's arm as they glanced around the cave they found themselves in the middle of.

"At least there's only one path," said Wednesday. "Divination did not show where Odrin went after coming down here." She stopped short as they came upon a perfectly round seam formed in the smooth stone face of an apparent dead end. Wednesday touched the wall. Her hands glided against the smooth stone. "You didn't say it was blocked."

Enid gaped. "Me? How was I supposed to know? I never came down here."

"You said you found the hatch in one of your loops."

"Yeah, the *hatch*. Yoko told me that Divina told her that Kent heard a rumor from Bianca that some students were growing weed down here, and I got curious. I didn't actually go down this far. Who do you take me for?"

"Someone who isn't keen on following a story to its end..." Wednesday sighed. "A moment then." She set an ear against the stone and tapped against it in a few different spots. They were careful, deliberate touches from what Enid could see. Then, without making a sound, the round plug of stone sank a few inches in and rolled aside.

"Whoa," said Enid. "That was impressive!"

"A simple pressurized mechanism with a concealed door jam. It's nothing anyone with a basic knowledge of lock systems couldn't figure out."

"Hey, credit where credit's due." They slipped through the round opening. It silently shut behind them. Enid jumped. "I really hope that didn't trap us down here."

"No turning back."

"People only say that when they're about to come across something dangerous."

"And me without my ax."

They now stood at the top of a set of stairs, and they walked down until the steps ended in a straight, smooth, gray cobblestone tunnel. It was lined with inert wall sconces, which stretched forward so far that it confused the eye.

"What the heck was Idrin doing here?" Enid descended and started down the hall first despite her rooted fear. "This is a lot nicer than most of the tunnels beneath the school. At least of the ones we've had to move through."

"Certainly a product of the early 19th century," Wednesday said, studying the walls with interest. "The minimal decomposition could mean it's probably been forgotten for several centuries now."

"Great..." Enid kept walking. The end of the tunnel didn't seem to get any closer. "I wish I didn't have this opinion at all, but I frankly prefer the old kind." She glanced at the smooth gray walls. "Doesn't it creep you out with how maintained it still is? And small? A wolf out in here would not be ideal. Are we close to the end?"

"I can't tell. Which means no, I think." Wednesday pulled out her phone and turned on the flashlight. "Some illumination might help."

"Actually, I'm pretty okay in the dark now that I've gone full werewolf, but good call." They continued in companionable silence for a few minutes. "You know, I'm still mad you had a phone over the summer and didn't let me know immediately. That's like basic rules of best friendship. We could've had so many inside jokes over the summer."

"Then I guess we're both fortunate because my father confiscated my device over the summer."

"Really? Can't imagine what you did for *that* to happen." Enid recalled the time when she happened to call Wednesday over the break, and a deep, timbered voice, that was not Wednesday's, picked up. They did end up having a pleasant conversation about a Tibetan monastery that lasted a good hour. It was a strange afternoon for sure.

"I did nothing," said Wednesday. "He merely wanted to watch some attention-rotting videos one day and never gave it back until I was forced to steal it back before the semester."

"How can you be sure of that?"

"Because the internal storage library was filled to the brim with screenshots of videos that someone of an average mind would find hilarious. No doubt to show my mother later."

"Your parents are so sweet," Enid cooed. "I hope to have a devotion to someone as deep as theirs someday."

"T rust me, it's nothing but obscene."

"T o an insider, sure," she argued, "but there' s something special to having such a deep connection with someone that you're desperate to always be by their side. A love like that is so rare it makes me jealous."

Wednesday scoffed. "I didn't take you as the jealous type. Regardless, it' s not necessary. One must only study techniques on how to be an adequate lover . You'll be fine."

"But that sounds so callous. It' s not about *studying* how to love someone—it's *feeling* it. You start to catch yourself doing things you normally wouldn't, all for the sake of your partner . It' s romantic."

Wednesday was quiet for a moment. The sound of her footsteps grew softer. "What if this person has spent their entire life suppressing their feelings so as to not hinder their adept development?"

Enid looked around the dark to hide a smile. Brushing her hair out of her face, she tucked it behind one round ear. "I think emotional suppression has the opposite effect, but I get your point. My advice to *those people* is to find someone who sticks by them despite all that and trust in their own charms because they probably have plenty of them." She bumped her shoulder gently against W ednesday's.

"Hmm."

They kept walking.

And walking.

It felt like Enid was passing through empty space—a hallway void of *anything*. The werewolf within her paced with agitation. Growling and howling until a tense pressure settled all over her.

"I feel weird. How do you not get claustrophobic in here?" she asked the other girl.

"To combat the corrosive poison of claustrophobia means finding peace within yourself," Wednesday said studiously. "It's a difficult panacea to commit to, but well worth the effort." She paused and then added, "Breathing helps too."

"Breathing?"

"Slow, regular breathing, as if you were meditating. It is one of the most effective methods for calming oneself."

Following her advice, Enid began to consciously inhale and exhale, taking care to maintain a steady tempo and to expel all the air from her lungs with each breath. Within a minute, the knot inside her gut loosened, her frown eased, and the presence of the invisible stressors surrounding her no longer seemed quite so tangible. Her inner wolf howled, and after an initial burst of trepidation, she listened without fear, for their baying had lost the power to unsettle her.

"Oh wow. That was crazy. Thanks," she said, grateful. Wednesday responded with a gracious tilt of her chin, then violently shuddered.

Enid jumped, and all her muscles tensed in anticipation. "What? What is it?"

Wednesday's gaze seemed to look inward. "You didn't feel that?"

"No? Feel what? A murderer? Alien? Mummy?"

"I felt like something passed through me."

"*Pass through you*? Pass through—oh my god, it's a fucking ghost!" With a quick flick of her wrist, Enid brandished her knife, pointing it directly at Wednesday. "There's a ghost inside you! You're possessed!"

"Doubtful. Though I suddenly find myself regretting giving you a weapon. Please point it somewhere else before you hurt yourself." Wednesday patted her body, unhurried. "I would never allow a ghost to possess me. That kind of phenomenon is meant for people with weak constitutions."

"That's exactly what a possessed person would say," Enid argued, unconvinced.

"I'm fine."

"Like I'd take your word for it." Enid looked over her roommate from head to toe. "We are in uncharted territory in a place no one has been through in decades following the mysterious death of a kid who may be involved in some kind of temporal magic that we cannot even fathom." She huffed, worn out. "I don't think it's crazy to say that I thoroughly believe we're gonna run into some ancient vampire who's been trapped down here asleep for 1000 years just waiting for two pretty teenage girls to wander by and suck the life force out of."

"You're right. That is crazy."

Enid shrugged. "Believe what you want. Yoko's told me some wild stories about her relatives, so I'm not putting zombie-feral-vampire-mummy off the list of things that could attack us down here."

"We'll be fine."

"How can you be so sure?"

Wednesday gave her a searching look, then smirked. "You'll protect me." Enid got a fuzzy, familiar warm feeling in her chest that bloomed with intensity. "Mainly because I don't have my ax."

"There it is..." Enid smiled despite herself. She looked behind them and saw no intruder or seam in the smooth stone hallway. It was utterly empty, just as it had been the entire time they'd been walking, though she wasn't sure if that was a good thing or not. "I don't see

anything,"she whispered to no ef fect as the sound clearly bounced off the stone. "Maybe your psychic abilities are flaring? T elling you we're on the right track?"

"It did feel akin to when I have a vision."There was a sudden glint in her eye. "Or maybe it *is* a ghost."

"*Okay* ,"she squeaked, "I *officially* hate this. We should turn around or at least wait until you get a proper vision before we keep going down this endless hallway of unknown death and ruin."

"Nonsense."She grabbed Enid' s hand and tugged her along. "If anything, I'm now more committed to getting to the bottom of this."

After at least ten more minutes, they finally came to another set of stairs. Though these were winding rather than straight. Enid and Wednesday climbed and climbed until the two of them came to the top, where they ended at a seemingly blank wall.

"Finally! Looks like the same door that was under the conservatory . You're up."Enid gently pushed W ednesday forward, still holding her knife tightly in her grip.

The other girl walked over to the wall and held up a hand against it. There was the sound of stone grinding against stone. After a minute of fiddling, Wednesday stepped back. "Actually , your strength may be needed here. The door is loose from the mechanism. One good shove should resolve it."

Enid easily pushed at the wall with her shoulder, and suddenly the large segment pivoted inward, rotating like a large, circular stone door. The two girls peered into the rounded opening.

Inside was a long, tall, open passageway , with ornately wrought walls that were lined with what appeared to be some kind of cubbyholes, most of which were empty, but not all. In some of the cubbyholes, Enid spied urns and…

"Skulls," she said aloud. Her hands clenched against her side. "A crypt?"

"Precisely ," said Wednesday with a hint of glee.

The crypt was large, with a big, round, central chamber, and only one smaller, narrow wing splitting off from it.

Not convinced of her prediction of death and ruin, Enid was hesitant to traverse any further. "What in the hell is a crypt doing here? Wherever *here* is."

"By my calculations, we're north of the backwoods, closer to Jericho."

"How do you know that?" Enid asked, impressed.

"GPS." Wednesday turned her phone to Enid, who scrambled to grasp her own phone in her pocket, which displayed no bars.

"How the heck do you have signal down here?"

"Apart from my father confiscating my phone, my Uncle Fester also stole my phone for a week during the summer while on his way to Canada for some festival. He was appalled that I was still using its standard operating software."

"He jailbroke it?"

"He was not in jail at the time, no."

"That's not what—never mind. Lemme see the map."

Wednesday held up a blank screen. "Unfortunately , it just died."

"Wow. Next loop, I'm teaching you proper phone etiquette," she deadpanned.

"I didn't realize there was a technique to use these devices."

"Trust me, there is, and it starts with charging your phone frequently." She grimaced as her foot got too close to a stray bone. "Still doesn't explain why there's a crypt here."

"Actually may have an answer," said Wednesday. "Back when my parents first abandoned me at Nevermore, I did my due diligence and facilitated a deep dive on this land's history. Apparently, there had been quite a few minor estates here before the Outcasts settled. Some baron or other nerdowell apparently just tore them down and decided to pave over them. No one thought much about what was underneath until the Outcasts started digging tunnels. Most of the crypts and basements have gotten flooded out—but this one is clearly in fairly good condition."

Enid hesitantly looked in a few of the cubby holes. There was a surprising lack of bones, or at the very least, they were so disintegrated that whatever they originally were was unfounded. She shivered. "It's as cold as a morgue."

"Actually find it quite balmy."

"You would," Enid grumbled. "Come on, I don't think what we're looking for is here, let's keep going."

"Hold that thought." She pointed to a corner that had been cleared of detritus long ago. "Backpack."

Propped up against the corner wall was an old dark colored backpack caked in a thick layer of dust. The faded Nevermore Academy insignia was patched all over it.

Inside were illegible notes, a disintegrating newspaper, and a single weathered photograph depicting Odrin and the other boy from Wednesday's vision. Their arms were wrapped around the other's shoulders, heads tilted against each other. The back of the photo, in faded ink, read: *Xavier & Odrin '17*.

Enid scrutinized the photo, hoping something would pop out at her, but nothing stood out.

"At least we know he was here," Wednesday said, pocketing the picture.

"No visions?"

She shook her head. "It's increasingly likely that our answers lie in the chamber beyond. That feeling I had a while back has not yet subsided and only grown stronger since being in here."

"What? Why didn't you say something?"

"You are easily frightened."

"But what if you dropped dead in the next thirty seconds?"

"Then I'm thankful we've found ourselves in a crypt. I don't see the issue."

"Oh my god"…

The single offshoot doorway from the crypt had collapsed at an odd angle, making passage seemingly impossible. With a quick assessment, Wednesday deduced the door had tilted off whatever mechanism was used to open it. She noticed to the right, a small sliver of wall had cracked open and appeared to lead to the main fulcrum for the door, festering amongst decades-old mold and mildew. It was a very tight squeeze.

Enid gagged. "Please don't tell me we have to go in there."

"Only one way to find out." Wednesday rolled up her sleeves and made for the small alcove.

"No!" Enid jumped up and blocked the path from Wednesday. "Let me do it."

"I thought you hated the idea of splitting up? Horror movie logic."

"That was when I was only the best friend. Love interests can stick around for at least one or two more sequels, but that's not the point! You're the only one who knows how to get back."

"We walked in a straight line."

She ignored her. "If *I* die, then at least you can lead a rescue team to recover my body."

"You're not dying, Enid," Wednesday said tightly. "You don't know what could be lurking in there. Between us, I'm the only one used to torturous instruments of bodily harm."

"Yeah, so? And I'm a werewolf. We could stay here arguing about who is better equipped, but at the end of the day, I know I can physically endure *way* more than you."

Wednesday shook her head, clearly irritated. "I should have brought my ax."

"You and your ax." Enid absentmindedly scratched at the three faintly scarred gash marks on her face.

Dark eyes tracked the movement intently. Her frown dropped ever so slightly. "Fine," she relented.

Enid sported a triumphant smirk. "I knew you'd come around to my way."

"I told you we should have brought Thing."

"No! I stand by my decision. What if something awful happened to him down here?"

"He's survived worse."

"Well, I wasn't willing to risk him."

"He would have."

"Whatever ."

The hole was incredibly narrow.

There was barely enough space for Enid to sidle against. Turning her head or body in any direction risked straining any number of muscles. Not to mention the absolute disgusting, slimy mildew that covered the walls. Centuries of wet moss and mold had grown into the crevices of broken rock and stone. The uneven ground beneath her was difficult to navigate, and bits of broken wall jutted out and cut all around her body.

Taking Wednesday's advice, she focused on her breathing to stave off a panic attack. "Say something," she called out to the other girl.

"What?"

"I need a distraction. This is literally *so* gross. Say something to distract me."

"Is it blood?"

"I wish. That I at least have experience with."

"Pity . I was hoping for blood." Wednesday was silent for a moment. "I've been thinking of my less-than-enthusiastic response to your affections. And I must admit, I regret not showing my interest in you more appropriately."

"*More appropriately*? What are you talking about?" Enid sputtered. "You call everything you've done till now *less than enthusiastic*?" A flash of the graveyard incident floated through her mind. "I can't wait to see what your *actual* enthusiasm looks like."

"Take the win, Enid." Wednesday pursed her lips. "I'll be clearer of my intentions from this point forward."

Enid smiled to herself, then a horrible thought crossed her mind. "Wait, no, this is the *opposite* of the kind of conversation we should be having. Horror—"

"Horror movie logic, yes. Get on with it. You're fine."

"Why am I doing this?" she muttered fearfully. "Ahh!"

"Enid?"

"Ugh. My hand touched something." She breathed shakily. "This is *so* gross. How much farther do I have to go? I can't really see shit."

"There should be an alcove coming up on your right side from what I saw. The latch for the door should be there."

Enid whimpered. "I can appreciate the weirdness of our school, but why are there so many abandoned underground passageways? This has to be some kind of fire code violation at this point."

"Technically, we should be under Jericho city limits, so it more than likely falls under their jurisdiction."

Enid felt around against the broken wall until her hand passed through the air. She pushed forward through the space, and until she bumped against a strange latch mechanism. Since it was an awkward angle, she fumbled with it for a second before realizing it was just a few inches out of reach. She could feel where several pulley systems had fallen off their track and just needed the extra push back in place to hopefully function.

Straining for her knife, Enid used its length to click the mechanisms into place.

A rumble from the outside signified something had shifted. Carefully making her way back to her roommate, she hesitated before walking out into the open.

"Did that open it? Or did I just release a killer mummy?"

"Mummies are already dead," Wednesday said. "We're more likely to inhale toxic gas that would kill us instantly than encounter something supernaturally deadly."

"I feel like you're completely disregarding your track record."

The door did, in fact, still work. It was completely lopsided and only halfway up, but it held strong to allow passage to both of the girls.

"No use gawking. Come on."

They ducked under the door into a room of complete darkness. Wednesday took one cautious step forward before Enid pulled on Wednesday's arm, who looked briefly annoyed at the action.

"Wait! Before we go further," she took a deep breath. "If we die, will you go on a date with me?"

Wednesday quirked an eyebrow with interest. "Paired death sounds like the perfect date."

"I mean," she sighed. "I'd like to survive and if we do,"—

From around the chamber, several candles suddenly light up. Each one flickered to life in a wave, instantly illuminating the space.

"I knew there was a vampire mummy!" Enid squealed but still smoothly moved in front of Wednesday and extended her claws. Her eyes narrowed, searching for a threat. A deep growl rumbled low in her chest.

Wednesday put a hand on her shoulder, breaking her feral focus. She whirled around at her with a fierce snarl before pulling back.

"Easy girl." Wednesday slid her hand down Enid's arm so as to hold her hand with her own.

"You've already almost died once," Enid said in a harsh whisper. "I'm not taking chances."

The larger chamber before them was not as impressively built as the rest of their trek. It looked almost carved out by desperate working hands instead of the measured opulence of the rest of the underground. The room itself was pretty bare bones. The magical candle lights, a small altar, and a few dozen boxes of decayed material and refuse were scattered about.

Along with something large and pale white, slumped over the altar in the middle.

There was only a single outlet branching outward, though it had caved in beyond help. Enid thought she could feel the slightest breeze coming from it.

"It's so normal." Enid relaxed once there was no threat she could easily spot.

"Disappointing," Wednesday said, stepping from behind her. "I was expecting an elaborate torture chamber."

"Maybe we should stop voicing our desires out loud."

Wading curiously through the room, Enid couldn't make much sense of it. It looked more like a desecrated laboratory than something she'd associate with a dead high schooler. At least until she came upon the mass in the middle of the room.

"What the..." As she approached the altar, her stomach seized. It was a human-sized skeleton. The bones were picked clean and mostly intact, draped over the elaborate-looking altar. "Do you think that's him?" Enid grimaced. "How fast is decomposition? This looks way too clean."

"It is," Wednesday said simply. "Or your vampire got to him."

"We'll see who's laughing when your body gets shriveled like a raisin." She stopped. "That was really mean. I'm sorry. I don't want

that to happen." Enid swiveled her head around the area, making sure no vampires got the jump on them.

Wednesday brushed past her and delicately touched a part of the hand that had fallen to the side. "Looks like whoever this was made an attempt at some form of spellcraft. It's a shame there isn't," Her hand touched the altar, and her head fell back, the whites of her eyes completely visible.

Enid was quick to catch her, getting a bit apprehensive when the vision seemed to go on longer than usual. She kept vigilant over her body but remained tense the entire time.

With a better opportunity to attentively observe the bones next to her, a look of recognition crossed Enid's face, and she frowned.

It was almost ten minutes before Wednesday started to stir.

"Are you okay?" Enid helped her sit up. "What happened? You didn't die, did you?"

"Grin," the girl clarified, looking over the skeleton. "He was a,"

"He's a werewolf."

Wednesday looked back at her, questioning. "How did you know?"

"His bones," she said almost monotonously. She pointed to the ribs and spine. "They need a certain kind of flexibility to break and extend once you wolf out. They're slightly different from a regular skeleton. Most people wouldn't be able to tell the difference. The spine elongates and bends," she passed her hands over the bleached white bones on the floor running down the length of the body, and retracted when she accidentally touched them. "They're slightly larger in shape than the average person."

"Impressive."

Enid's eyes dimmed. "Yeah, you can thank my mom for thinking I was defective and taking me to every werewolf doctor in the country." She frowned, thinking back to that time in her life—her *entire* life until a few months ago. "You pick up these things after the fortieth visit and a useless explanation on werewolf anatomy."

"I hope you feel no shame towards yourself for the actions of your mother," Wednesday said gently. "You offer far more value to the world than your ability to wolf out."

"While I appreciate it," Enid smiled, thankful, "you don't have to say all that. She's eased up a little. But I don't wanna talk about her—what did you see?"

Wednesday recounted her vision.

A flash of moments of Idrin Gornum's life up until his death.

A supposed Normie from a family of Outcasts, allowed to attend Nevermore Academy for extracurriculars until his subsequent wolf out the summer before his senior year. To finally be fully welcomed as an Outcast should have been a joyous thing. But for Idrin, he was leaving behind Kit, his clandestine boyfriend from his old Normie life. Tensions between Normies and Outcasts were far more strained during that time, and they knew, even in secret, their relationship would be forced to be short-lived.

With the wealth of mystical knowledge of Nevermore's library at his fingertips, Idrin began to dream up an idea to give them that time back. Risking punishment for love, Idrin put himself wholeheartedly into this endeavor and started to neglect all other aspects of his life. Though he never told Kip about his plan, wanting to save the surprise until he was sure it would work.

Eventually, everything fell into place, and he created a spell so potent it could alter time itself.

"The two of them found these tunnels before Udrin started attending Nevermore," Wednesday explained. "So he used it as a workshop. The excess of magic once the spell was cast caused the other walls to collapse and the door to jam like we found it. There was nothing he could do but die. Slow and agonizing." She gave a pitiful look toward the unmoving skeleton. "Not a targeted attack on you or me. Just unfortunate hubris made by someone who wasn't willing to face dejection."

Enid didn't know how to feel. "This whole thing was because he wanted to spend time with his boyfriend?"

"A feat 50 years too late."

They sat with Udrin in respective somber silence before Enid perked up. "I wonder if anyone actually knew what he was doing. The school literally said nothing about his death or even included him in the yearbook. Did they know about Kit? It makes you wonder"…

Wednesday glanced at her. "We can do a more thorough deep dive on him and the school, if you want."

The thought of letting this drag out more than it already had did not appeal to Enid. "I think I'm okay with letting this die with us. Is it mean to say I'm glad this ended up as an unrelated mishap rather than a personal assault on us?"

Wednesday nodded. "Though I do love death, I would have to agree."

She frowned ruthfully at Udrin's bones. "He created a time loop just to ensure he would be able to spend time with his boyfriend, knowing they'd probably split up in the end. And then he *died*. That really fucking sucks."

"A worthy endeavor for someone who, unfortunately, was brilliant." Wednesday stood and began toiling over the altar, carefully moving

drin' s bones while Enid stalked around the perimeter. "I'm amazed this still worked."

"*You're* amazed?"

"I can appreciate an experiment for what it is. I'm not sure I can even properly explain what it is I'm looking at. Innovation at its finest," she said with slight awe. "We researched everything we could about time loops. No one was close to achieving this kind of temporal manipulation. He had a specific target and purpose, and even achieved a delayed reaction from so far away. Since we know he was a werewolf, that was probably why you were afflicted without any meaning. The spell mistook you for him."

"Yeah." Enid was partially convinced. "But why did you become aware so late?"

They were both silent for a moment before Wednesday turned to her. "You kissed me."

Enid looked away sheepishly. "I thought I already apologized for that."

Wednesday waved her hand. "That was the point of this. To trap him and his boyfriend in a time loop."

"Me kissing you made you aware?"

She shrugged. "It's one theory."

"That seems weirdly specific," she said, unconvinced. "Did he expect his boyfriend not to be impacted?"

"Maybe he knew it could only influence one person. All plans need parameters. Otherwise, the majority of them would fail at the first bout."

"It's kind of romantic," Enid commented offhandedly. "But kissing?"

f I were casting an experimental spell on my parents, I'd do the same. Know thy enemy. Or lover, in this case. Less cause that someone else would be brought into it." Wednesday eyed her. "Let's just be thankful you have no self-control."

"*Excuse me*?"

"I just meant I'd never want you going through something like this on your own again."

Enid paused, contemplating Wednesday's words. "Could we? Or someone? How do we know this won't turn on again in another 50 years?"

"I don't think we have to worry too much about it being replicated." Wednesday picked up a scrap piece of paper that had rudimentary directions and an ingredient list. She read through it carefully. "If this is correct, then the materials needed can't be easily obtained, as most of this stuff is now illegal or strictly sanctioned." She glanced at Enid carefully. "Like any other magical ritual, desecrating this altar should reverse the effects."

Enid held her breath. This was it. The end of her ordeal. She nodded resolutely, more than ready for this to be over. "Let's do it. I don't want anyone going through what I did. It's *cruel*. It may have been done out of love but—"

"Good intention rarely stands."

"And zero murders since our last murder…"

"That you know of."

"That we know—don't say it like that," she whined.

Wednesday looked almost mournful as she glided her hand over the altar for a moment before turning around, grabbing a candle off the mantle, and setting the contents of the altar on fire. It burned slowly,

but did eventually catch a scrap of old, weathered paper, and struck up an inferno rather quickly. The two girls backed away from the fire and watched it burn to completion.

Halfway through their waiting, Wednesday threw the picture of Kit and Ichorin into the fire.

"Some things are not meant for the world," Wednesday said.

Enid stared at the glow of the altar. Even on fire, she could see the care taken in every aspect of it. "He wanted time," she said mournfully. "That's all..." As they watched the fire burn slowly, its components melting and curling on each other, she turned to Wednesday. The glow of the fire spread a slight warm tone onto her pallid skin. "Will you go on a date with me? I realized I jumped the gun kissing you, but I don't think I'm that sorry anymore since it got us to this point."

"I gathered."

Enid frowned. "Can I, like, get my whole thing out? I'm vibing off adrenaline here. I don't know how much I have left in me."

"Apologies. Continue."

Enid took a breath. "I think you're really amazing, and I feel like we've really bonded over the year we've known each other. I wouldn't want to be in a life-threatening situation with anyone but you, and that's the truth." She laughed nervously. "I asked Thing a few loops back where you'd maybe like to go, and while I still think graveyards are *major* creepy ~~but~~ also kind of sexy, your fault by the way. I don't know, maybe we can compromise and go in the afternoon? I'll even settle for a walk at midnight as long as we don't jump into any more graves. I can work back up to that if you want"... She trailed off.

"Okay," Wednesday said simply.

"That's it?"

"What do you mean?"

"I don't know, I thought you'd try to intimidate me and I'd have to convince you more."

Wednesday quirked an eyebrow. "Would you prefer I have you beg for it?"

Enid's mouth went dry. "We really need to work on the things you say to people."

"I'll go on a date with you, Enid. There's no reason to feel intimidated. We've already confessed our attraction for each other. Everything now is just following the order of things."

"Oh, I'm not intimidated," Enid said with a laugh. "You're going to be so blown away by our date that you'll wish you prepared your heart more because you're gonna fall so in love with me it'll make your head spin."

"Then I look forward to your efforts."

"You still sound condescending."

Wednesday smirked slightly. "It's my nature."

They sat together for some time, just watching the fire until the last dredges of the altar were nothing but smoking bits of ash and dying embers.

Enid rubbed her hands together nervously. "So, do you think it worked?"

"We've desecrated the altar. I believe it was the only thing keeping the spell in effect."

Enid's alarm on her watch went off.

"Oh, fuc—"

SATURDAY

Enid stared at the blinking numbers on her watch and held her breath. It beeped for a solid minute before going silent.

11:46

11:47

11:48

Time itself seemed to jump back into Enid, and she gasped, breath coming out shaky and clipped. "Is it done?"

Wednesday looked equally trepidatious. "You've never gone past this moment in time?"

She shook her head. Too scared to speak.

Wednesday, in an unexpected show of clemency, held her hand out for Enid. "Let's find a way out of here."

While the way out was simply retracing their steps, the trek was daunting. Every step Enid took reverberated through her bones like she was walking in slow motion, waiting for some kind of detonation to occur that would rocket her back to that same sunshining morning.

She held Wednesday's hand in a vice grip the entire time. The other girl didn't complain or mention it because she was holding Enid's hand just as tightly.

By the time they made it back to the Ophelia Hall, it was still dark. The early morning hours of the day still held the stillness of nighttime. Their dorm was quiet. The encroaching darkness streaming into their room loomed over the pair as if just waiting for

the moment they looked away, and it would all reverse, and the sun would rise behind their eyelids to indicate their efforts failed.

"I don't want to fall asleep," Enid said, pacing the boundary between the two halves of their room. "How do I stay awake?"

"I could give you pointers." Wednesday methodically watched her pace back and forth from her perch on the bed. "I once stayed awake for 72 hours straight."

"Why? That sounds awful."

"The brain is a fragile organ. I only wished to test its limits and hallucinate."

"Really?" She made a noise. "I thought the purity of a sober mind would appeal to you more."

Wednesday stared at her, impressed. "I admit I was young and immature once."

Enid did eventually fall asleep. She woke up with a slight crick in her neck, finding her head resting on Wednesday's shoulder. Their hands were interlocked.

The next minute felt like a dream. Or the cusp of a nightmare. The heroine of a movie going towards the door that would either invite her doom or gift her salvation.

Wednesday's face, also awake, betrayed nothing, and she was almost grateful for it.

There was no familiar birdsong. The sun was completely hidden behind a rain-induced cloudy sky. The yells of students outside were foreign and distant.

The loop was officially over.

"How do you feel?" Wednesday asked her after allowing Enid a respectful amount of time to stare out the window in shock.

Enid wasn't sure how to answer that since she honestly didn't have any words except, "Your shoulder is really bony."

"Thank you."

Then she cried.

Something greater than catharsis. More than relief. Not quite freedom. Not routine. It was almost senseless what she felt. There was no name for it. Just a feeling that existed, finally expunged.

She was quiet for a minute.

Enid could finally move on with her life. She sniffled. "Do you think we can skip class Monday?"

"And do what?" Wednesday looked amused.

"I was thinking a stay-in kind of day."

The other girl seemed to think about it honestly, then ruptured Enid's world. "Don't you have a test?"

"Shit!" She exploded. "That can't be—I can't take this test. I'll fail!"

"Didn't you say you studied?"

"That was like eight weeks ago!" Panic-filled cries reverberated in their dorm. "Oh my god, I'm going to fail all my classes! I don't remember anything!"

"Nonsense." Wednesday was the epitome of calm. "I'll help you study."

"You will?"

"I can't date someone who underperforms academically. I have standards."

"I'm too panicked to care. Thank you!"

Chapter End Notes

Free of one stress-inducing situation and right into another one. Enid can't catch a break. Sorry, girl...
This was literally so much fun to write, and I'm happy it finally saw the light of day. Yay! This one was a true indulgence for me, so thanks for sticking with it.

Please let me know your thoughts. I love to read them. And as always, thank you so so so much for reading!

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